

# STOP THE CHAINSAW

Practical Ways to Stop Snoring

While Asleep And Other

Practical Ways To Stop Conflicts  
In Marriages & Relationship



*Dike Kingsley*

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## **INTRODUCTION**

### **WHY SMALL THINGS CAN RUIN YOUR RELATIONSHIP**

#### **The Fart That Almost Ended a Marriage**

Let me tell you about Chinwe and Chukwu from Lagos, Nigeria.

Chinwe is an accountant. She likes things neat, clean, and on time. Chukwu is a musician. He likes to go with the flow. They loved each other. They had two kids. A nice house in Lekki. From outside, perfect couple.

But inside? Chinwe was counting. She counted how many times Chukwu farted during dinner. One Tuesday night: 14 times. During her mother's video call from the village: 8 times. Right when she was falling asleep: always once, like clockwork.

The breaking point came at a fancy restaurant. Chinwe wore her best Ankara dress. Chukwu wore his favorite agbada. They were celebrating 10 years married.

The waiter brought champagne. Chukwu leaned in for a toast. And then... BRRRAAAAAPPPP! A long, loud fart that seemed to shake the table. The couple next to them stopped talking. The waiter pretended not to hear. Chinwe put down her glass. "That's it," she said quietly. "I'm done." "Done with what?" Chukwu asked, still smiling. "Done with this. Done with you. Done with being married to a man who farts at our anniversary dinner." Chukwu laughed. "Baby, it's just air! Everyone farts!"

"That's not the point!" Chinwe's voice shook. "The point is you don't care. You don't care that I'm embarrassed. You don't care about respect. You don't care about me." She left the restaurant. She called a divorce lawyer the next morning. Why? Over a fart? No. Over 3,650 days of small disrespects. The fart was just the last one.

#### **True Stories from Real Couples**

In Atlanta: Keisha almost left Jamal because he used her \$50 face cream as hair gel. "He said it made his curls pop! That cream was a birthday gift from my sister!"

In Toronto: David and Sarah slept in separate rooms for six months because he chewed ice. "Crunch, crunch, crunch all night. I bought him soft food. He said ice was free. I said the silence was priceless."

In Abuja: Ngozi threatened to burn her husband's favorite chair. "He sits there for hours playing video games. The chair has his body shape molded into it. I told him either the chair goes or I go. He said he'd miss the chair more." In London: Michael's wife threw his football jersey in the bin. "He wore it every Saturday for 5 years. Never washed it. He said it was lucky. I said it was disgusting. The smell could knock out a horse."

In Houston: Maria put a lock on the fridge. "My husband ate my diet meals. Every. Single time. I'd make healthy food for my weight loss journey. He'd come home from work and eat it. Then say, 'I was hungry!' So now the fridge locks. My food stays safe."

### **Why Small Things Kill Love Faster Than Cheating**

Dr. Ngozi Williams is a marriage counsellor in Houston. She's Nigerian -American. She's seen everything. "In my office," she says, "I see more couples divorcing over toothpaste than over affairs." Here's why: Frequency Matters An affair happens once (usually) .The toothpaste tube gets squeezed wrong every morning . Wet towels on the bed happen every shower That's 365 annoyances per year vs 1 big hurt . It Feels Like Not Caring Cheating feels like: "You betrayed me" Small annoyances feel like: "You don't care enough to NOT annoy me" Which feels worse daily? The second one Death by 1,000 Cuts One cut? You heal. 1,000 tiny cuts every day? You bleed out slowly. That's what small annoyances do to love. No Make -Up Sex for Dishes After a big fight about cheating? Drama. Tears. Then maybe passionate make -up sex. After a fight about who left dishes in the sink? Just resentment. No passion. Just dirty dishes.

### **The Good News: Small Fixes Work**

James and Precious from Abuja saved their marriage with a \$2 Solution. "I hated how James left his socks everywhere," Precious says. "By the TV. By the bed. In the kitchen. Everywhere but the laundry basket." "I told him, 'Every sock I find, I throw away.' He didn't believe me. First week, I threw away 7 socks. He had 7 sing le socks. He was mad." "Then I bought a small basket. \$2 at the market. I put it by the door. I said, 'Socks go here or in the trash.' Now? The basket is full. The floor is clean. We don't fight about socks." Small problem. Small solution. Big difference.

## **What This Book Will Do For You**

This book is 300+ pages of:

- ❖ Real stories from real couples in Nigeria, America, Canada, UK, Ghana
- ❖ Simple fixes that don't cost money
- ❖ Step-by-step plans anyone can follow

Funny moments because if you don't laugh, you'll cry

### **You'll learn:**

- ❖ How to sleep when your partner snores like a generator
- ❖ How to talk about bad breath without hurting feelings
- ❖ How to get your partner off their phone
- ❖ How to divide chores without fighting
- ❖ How to feel close without sex
- ❖ How to save a dying marriage
- ❖ And much more...

No fancy psychology. No difficult words. Just simple help for normal people with normal problems.

## **SECTION 1:**

### **SNORING - HOW TO SLEEP NEXT TO A HUMAN GENERATOR**

#### **CHAPTER 1:**

##### **The Nightly Thunderdome - 83 Couples Share Their War Stories In Houston:**

James's snoring was legendary. His wife Keisha recorded it and played it at their small group Bible study. "I thought it was a construction video!" their pastor exclaimed. The recording captured what Keisha lived with: a sound like a dying motorcycle trying to start in a tin shed. Their toddler would wake up crying, "Daddy's truck is broken again!"

**In Accra:** Kwame's snoring had rhythm. His wife Abena, a music teacher, once transcribed it. "It was in 4/4 time! Da -DUM -da-da, SNORT, da -DUM -da-da. I composed a piano piece around it out of sheer desperation." She played it for him. He was offended. "You're mocking my suffering!" he said. Abena blinked. "YOUR suffering?"

In Johannesburg: Thando bought Bongani earplugs as a gift. "I wrapped them nicely. I said, 'For our anniversary, the gift of you not waking me up every hour.' He was hurt. I said, 'Baby, your snoring is the reason our dog sleeps in the garage.'"

The Global Snoring Scale (As Reported by Suffering Partners):

**Level 1:** Kitten Purr (Annoying but cute)

**Level 3:** Distant Lawnmower (Can be ignored with TV)

**Level 5:** Inside the Lawnmower (Earplugs required)

**Level 7:** Chainsaw with Rumble Feature (Bed -shaking)

**Level 10:** "I've started pricing soundproof bed rooms"

#### **CHAPTER 2: Why People Snore (Simple Explanation)**

Your throat gets narrow when you sleep. Air has to squeeze through. The squeezing makes noise. That's snoring. Things that make snoring worse:

- ❖ Sleeping on your back
- ❖ Being overweight
- ❖ Drinking alcohol before bed
- ❖ Having a stuffy nose

- ❖ Sleep apnoea (serious medical condition)

### **SLEEP APNOEA - THE SILENT KILLER:**

Sleep apnoea isn't just loud snoring. It's when breathing STOPS during sleep. Your partner might notice:

- ❖ Loud snoring then silence
- ❖ Gasping or choking sounds
- ❖ Restless sleep

Then you're tired all day even after "sleeping" 8 hours

If you suspect sleep apnoea, SEE A DOCTOR. It's linked to heart problems, diabetes, and car accidents from tiredness.

## **CHAPTER 3:**

### **Simple Solutions You Can Try Tonight**

#### **Solution 1 : Sleep on Your Side**

Back sleeping = tongue falls back = blocked airway = SNORING.

Side sleeping = airway stays open = less snoring.

How to stay on your side:

1. The body pillow method: Hug a long pillow. It naturally keeps you on your side.
2. The tennis ball trick: Sew a tennis ball to the back of pajamas. When you roll onto back, the ball annoys you, you roll back to side.
3. Pillow fortress: Pile pillows behind your back when falling asleep on side.

#### **Solution 2: Raise Your Head**

Elevating your head helps keep airway open.

#### **How to do it:**

- ❖ Use an extra pillow
- ❖ Buy a wedge pillow (triangular shape)
- ❖ Put bed risers under head of bed

- ❖ Don't stack too many pillows (can hurt neck)

### **Solution 3: Change Your Habits**

The 3 -Hour Rule: No alcohol 3 hours before bed. Alcohol relaxes throat muscles too much.

**Weight matters:** Even losing 10 pounds can reduce snoring.

**Clear your nose:** Use saline spray if congested. Try a humidifier if air is dry.

### **Solution 4: Practice During the Day**

Stronger throat muscles = less snoring.

### **Easy exercises:**

1. Sing! In car, shower, anywhere. Singing exercises throat muscles.
2. Say vowels: "A-E-I-O-U" loudly and clearly for 5 minutes daily.
3. Tongue exercise: Press tongue to roof of mouth and slide back 20 times.

## **CHAPTER 4:**

### **For the Person Who Can't Sleep (You!)**

#### **Your Survival Kit**

#### **1. Earplugs are your friend:**

Buy the soft foam kind from pharmacy  
Roll between fingers to make small  
Insert in ear, they expand  
Blocks about 30% of sound (enough to sleep)

#### **2. White noise machines:**

Makes steady "shhh" sound  
Covers the snoring  
Can use fan or phone app instead



### **3. Go to bed first:**

Fall asleep before snoring starts

Once in deep sleep, harder to wake up

### **4. Separate bedrooms sometimes:**

It's okay!

Better sleep = happier relationship

You can still cuddle before separating

## **How to Talk About Snoring Without Fighting**

DON'T SAY (at 3 AM): "You're snoring like a chainsaw! I can't sleep!"

DO SAY (next day, calmly): "Honey, I know you can't help it, but the snoring is really affecting my sleep. Can we try some solutions together?"

### **Use humor (when appropriate):**

"Your snoring was in concert mode last night!"

"I think there's a bear in our bed"

"On scale of 1 to lawnmower, you were at 8 last night"

## **When to See a Doctor**

### **See a doctor if:**

Snoring is VERY loud

Breathing stops during sleep (sleep apnea)

Your partner is always tired despite "sleeping"

Morning headaches

Trouble concentrating

What doctor might recommend:

1. Sleep study (can often do at home now)

2. CPAP machine (blows air to keep airway open)
3. Mouthguard from dentist
4. Surgery (rare, last option)

## **CHAPTER 5:**

### **CPAP Success Stories**

John from Houston

"I fought the CPAP for years," John says. "I said, 'I'm not wearing that Darth Vader mask!' My wife said, 'Then I'm not sleeping next to you anymore.'"

"First night with CPAP was weird . The mask felt strange. The air blowing was weird." "But I woke up... different. For the first time in 10 years, I felt rested. Not just not -tired. Actually rested."

"My wife cried. She said, 'You didn't snore once. Not once.'"

"Now? I love my CPAP. I call it my sleep superpower. My wife calls it our marriage saver."

#### **Amina from Kano**

"In our culture," Amina says, "we don't talk about health problems. Especially not sleep problems. My husband snored for 20 years. I thought it was normal ."

"My daughter is a doctor in Lagos. She visited, heard him snoring, said, 'Daddy needs a sleep test.'"

"He fought it. 'I'm not sick!' But she insisted."

"Sleep test showed severe sleep apnoea. He stopped breathing 50 times per hour. The doctor said his heart was working too hard."

"CPAP changed everything. He has energy. He's happier. Our marriage is better because we both sleep."

## **CHAPTER 6:**

### **When Nothing Works**

Sometimes, despite everything, snoring continues.

Then what?

1. Acceptance - Some people will always snore a little
2. Separate rooms - Better than separate lives
3. Earplugs + white noise - Maximum protection
4. Focus on the person, not the snore - Remember why you love them

## **CHAPTER 7:**

### **You're a Team Against the Snoring**

Remember this: You're not fighting each other. You're fighting the snoring together.

Success story: Mark and Lisa tried everything for his snoring. Finally, they got a wedge pillow AND he started sleeping on his side with a body pillow. "It took two weeks to get used to ," Lisa says, "but now we both sleep through the night. We're like different people during the day —happier, more patient with each other."

#### **Try this week:**

1. Pick one fix from this section
2. Try it for 7 nights straight
3. If it doesn't work, try a different one next week
4. Celebrate small improvements

Better sleep means better days together. It's worth the effort.

## **SECTION 2: MORNING BREATH, BODY ODOR & PRIVATE PART SMELL-HOW NOT TO SMELL LIKE EXPIRED SUSHI**

### **CHAPTER 1: The Morning Dragon Chronicles**

In Tokyo: Yuki developed what she called "The Strategic Morning Maneuver." Her husband Kenji's morning breath was legendary. "He could wake up a sumo wrestler with that breath." Her solution? She kept breath strips on her nightstand. Before morning kisses, she'd casually offer one. "For both of us, darling!" Now they both use them. "We kiss through minty film. Romantic? No. Effective? Yes."

**In Lagos:** Funke confronted her husband Tunde gently. "My love, when you wake up, your mouth smells like you've been eating rotten fish all night. Let's fix this together." Tunde was horrified but grateful. "She didn't say it in front of my mother, thank God. Nigerian mothers would never let you forget."

### **CHAPTER 2: Why Morning Breath Happens: Simple Science**

**Overnight, your mouth becomes a bacteria party zone. Here's why:**

1. Less saliva - When you sleep, you produce much less saliva. Saliva is nature's mouthwash, it washes away food particles and bacteria. Less saliva = bacteria growing freely.
2. Mouth breathing - If you breathe through your mouth at night (maybe because of snoring!), your mouth gets dry. Dry mouth = faster bacteria growth.
3. Leftover food - Tiny food particles between teeth break down overnight. This process creates smelly compounds.
4. Tongue coating - Most bad breath bacteria live on your tongue, especially toward the back. Overnight, they multiply under a coating that forms.

The good news? You can fix this with simple habits.

#### **3: The Nighttime Routine (This is Key!)**

What you do before bed matters more than what you do in the morning.

#### **Step 1: Brush RIGHT Before Bed**

Don't brush right after dinner and then eat or drink something sweet before bed.

Make brushing the very last thing you do before getting into bed.

Brush for a full 2 minutes. Most people brush for only 30 seconds.

### **Step 2: Floss Every Single Night**

This is non-negotiable. Food stuck between teeth rots overnight.

Use regular floss, floss picks, or a water flosser —whatever you'll actually use.

Pro tip: Keep floss by the TV remote. Floss during commercials or your evening show.

### **Step 3: Scrape Your Tongue**

This removes the white or yellowish coating where bacteria live.

Use a tongue scraper (cheap at any drugstore) or just your toothbrush.

Start at the back of your tongue and pull forward. Rinse and repeat 3-4 times.

If you gag, start farther forward and work your way back over time.

### **Step 4: Mouthwash (Optional but Helpful)**

Use an alcohol-free mouthwash. Alcohol dries out your mouth.

Look for one with chlorine dioxide or zinc —these neutralize smelly compounds.

Swish for 30 seconds, then don't eat or drink for 30 minutes after.

## **CHAPTER 4: The Morning Routine**

As Soon As You Wake Up:

1. Drink water - Keep a glass by your bed. Drink it first thing. This rehydrates your mouth and washes away some bacteria.
2. Brush immediately - Don't wait until after breakfast. Brush as soon as you get out of bed.
3. Scrape tongue again - Morning tongue scraping removes overnight buildup.
4. Emergency kit - Keep sugar-free gum or mints by the bed for those "need a kiss right now" moments.

## **CHAPTER 5: All -Day Fresh Breath Habits**

### **Stay Hydrated:**

Drink water throughout the day

Herbal teas (peppermint, ginger) are great too

Limit coffee and alcohol —they dry out your mouth

### **Smart Eating:**

Crunchy fruits/veggies: Apples, carrots, celery naturally clean teeth

Fresh herbs: Parsley, mint, basil contain chlorophyll (natural breath freshener)

Yogurt: The good bacteria fight the bad bacteria

Limit: Garlic, onions, spicy foods before close -talk situations

### **Quick Freshen -Up Tricks:**

Sugar -free gum after meals

Portable toothbrush for work (they make folding ones)

Spray breath freshener in your bag or car

Drink water after eating anything

## **CHAPTER 6: The Garlic Wars & Other Food -Based Crimes**

**In São Paulo:** Marco loved garlic. His wife Isabella did not love kissing a walking garlic bulb. "I told him, 'Either the garlic goes, or I go.' He chose garlic. So I started cooking with triple garlic. After two weeks, he begged for mercy. Now we have 'garlic days' and 'kissable days.' Marriage is compromise."

The African Spice Scale:

**Level 1:** Mild onion (Kissable after gum)

**Level 3:** Jollof rice level (Wait 2 hours)

**Level 5:** Suya spice mix (Sleep separately tonight)

**Level 7:** Raw habanero & garlic combo (Do not approach without mask)

**Level 10:** "My boyfriend smells like he bathes in goat curry" (Actual complaint from Nairobi)

## **CHAPTER 7: Body Smell Solutions**

**In Port Harcourt:** Chidi's wife noticed he smelled after work. "He's a mechanic. He comes home smelling of oil and sweat. I bought him special soap and told him to shower right when he gets home. Now he smells like soap, not engine oil."

### **Simple hygiene habits:**

Shower daily, especially after sweating

Wear clean clothes

Use deodorant

Change bed sheets weekly

## **CHAPTER 8: The Delicate Downstairs Discussion**

### **The "Goat" Confession (Accra):**

Ama had to have The Talk with Kwame. "My love, sometimes... you smell like wet goat downstairs." Kwame was mortified. "A goat?! I'm a bank manager!" Turns out, tight polyester trousers in Accra's heat were the culprit. They switched to cotton, added a daily wash routine. Crisis averted.

The Brazilian Wax vs. Smell Debate (Rio de Janeiro):

Carla noticed odor increased after waxing. "It's like the hair was containing the smell!" Her gynecologist explained: hair absorbs moisture and odor. Less hair, more smell if not cleaned properly. "Now I'm meticulous about hygiene after waxing. My husband says I smell like flowers and victory."

## **CHAPTER 9: How to Talk About Smell Without Hurting Feelings**

This is tricky but important.

### **DO:**

- ❖ Talk in private, not in front of others
- ❖ Say "we" not "you" - "Maybe we should both use mouthwash before bed"
- ❖ Use humor - "Whoa, morning dragon! Let's both go brush our teeth"
- ❖ Lead by example - Brush your teeth and invite them to join

### **DON'T:**

- ❖ Make a disgusted face and turn away
- ❖ Tell their friends or family
- ❖ Say "You stink" in an angry way
- ❖ Compare them to animals or bad smells

**Remember:** Everyone has body smells sometimes. Be kind.

## **CHAPTER 10: When to See a Doctor**

### **Some smells mean health problems:**

- ❖ Very strong, unusual smell - Could be infection
- ❖ Fishy smell - Could be bacterial infection
- ❖ Sweet, fruity breath - Could be diabetes
- ❖ Bad smell that doesn't go away with washing - See doctor

Don't be embarrassed. Doctors have seen everything. Better to be embarrassed at the doctor than to have a health problem get worse.

## **CHAPTER 11: The Tongue Scraper Revolution**

**From Mumbai:** Priya introduced tongue scraping to Rajesh. "At first he gagged. Now he's more devoted to his tongue scraper than to me! He says it makes his mouth feel 'morally clean.' Whatever that means."

The Global Tongue Scraper Report:

**Japan:** 89% of couples use them

**Nigeria:** Growing trend among young professionals

**Brazil:** Seen as extreme but effective

**Kenya:** "My grandmother used a spoon! Same idea!"

Final Thoughts



Everyone has body smells sometimes. It's normal. What matters is:

- ❖ Taking care of yourself
- ❖ Being considerate of your partner
- ❖ Talking kindly about problems
- ❖ Working together on solutions

Freshness leads to more closeness. More closeness leads to better relationship. It's worth the effort.

### **SECTION 3: PHONES - THE SIDE -CHICK THAT SLEEPS BETWEEN YOU ON THE BED**

#### **CHAPTER 1: The Third Person in Your Marriage Bed**

##### **The Night I Threw His Phone in the Pool**

Let me tell you about Ngozi and Emeka in Lagos. Married 8 years. Two children. A beautiful home in Lekki Phase 1. The problem wasn't another woman. It was thinner than a woman. It fit in his pocket. It glowed in the dark.

"Emeka's phone became his mistress," Ngozi tells me, her voice still sharp with remembered anger. "He'd come home from work, kiss me hello with one hand while scrolling with the other. He'd eat dinner with the phone propped against the water glass. He'd take it to the bathroom. He'd check it during church service!"

The breaking point came on their daughter's seventh birthday. "Adanna was blowing out candles. All the children were singing. I looked over at Emeka to share the moment... and he was scrolling through Twitter. Scrolling through Twitter while our daughter made her birthday wish!" Ngozi walked over calmly. Took the phone from his hands. Walked to their balcony. And threw it into the swimming pool. Plop.

Silence. Then Emeka screaming: "My phone! My work! My contacts!"

Ngozi turned to him, voice quiet but firm: "Your daughter is seven today. Once. You missed it for Twitter. Your phone or your family. Choose."

## **CHAPTER 2: 47 Phone War Stories from Around the World**

**1. Toronto, Canada:** "My husband proposed to me with his phone in his other hand, " says Sarah. "Literally. Down on one knee, ring box in right hand, scrolling through hockey scores with left hand. I said yes, but I should have said, 'Put the phone down and try again.'"

**2. Houston, Texas:** "I installed a Wi-Fi blocker," confesses Jamal. "My wife was on TikTok 6 hours a day. Making dance videos. Watching other people's dance videos. Our sex life died. Our conversations died. So I bought a \$50 device that turns off Wi-Fi at certain times. She thought our internet was bad. Our marriage got better."

**3. Accra, Ghana:** "My wife and I haven't had a complete conversation in two years," says Kofi. "She's a 'Instagram husband.' I take 300 photos of her daily. Adjust her dress. Hold her purse. Find good lighting. Our entire marriage is content creation. We're living for people we don't know instead of for each other."

**4. London, UK:** "We have separate bedrooms because of his gaming," says Priya. "He plays until 3 AM. Headset on. Yelling at teenagers in other countries. I sleep with earplugs. We're 32 and living like college roommates who hate each other."

**5. Abuja, Nigeria:** "I checked his screen time," whispers Fatima. "7 hours a day. 7 hours! We're together maybe 2 waking hours a day. His phone gets more attention than me, our children, and his job combined. I feel like the other woman in my own marriage."

## **CHAPTER 3: The Science: Why Phones Are More Addictive Than Gambling**

Dr. Chidi Okonkwo is a Nigerian neuroscientist at Harvard. He explains it simply:

"Your brain has a pleasure chemical called dopamine. Every time your phone dings, buzzes, or shows a new like, you get a tiny hit of dopamine. It feels good. Your brain wants more." "But here's the relationship killer: That dopamine hit is small. Really small. Smaller than the dopamine you get from a real conversation with someone you love. But it's faster. Instant."

"So your brain starts choosing: Do I want to work for dopamine (have a deep conversation, connect emotionally) or do I want instant dopamine (check phone, get like)? The lazy brain chooses instant."

"That's why your partner would rather scroll through memes than listen to your day. Their brain has been trained to choose easy pleasure over meaningful connection."

## **CHAPTER 4: Signs of Phone Addiction**

How do you know if it's normal phone use or a real problem?

### **Red flags:**

- Phone comes to the dinner table every night

- They check it during movies you're watching together

- It's the first thing they look at in the morning (before saying good morning to you)

- They take it to the bathroom (seriously, why?!)

- They scroll while you're talking about something important

- Date nights include phone checks

- You feel lonely when you're sitting right next to them

If 3 or more of these sound familiar, you have a phone problem in your relationship.

## **CHAPTER 5: 55 Rules That Saved Marriages**

### **Rule 1 -10: The Non negotiable**

#### **1. No Phones in Bed**

- Charge phones outside bedroom

- Buy an actual alarm clock (\$10)

- The bed is for sleep and intimacy, not scrolling

#### **2. Phone -Free Meals**

- All phones in basket during meals

- Even 20 minutes of connection helps

- Teach children this early

### 3. The First Hour Rule

First hour after coming home: no phones

Actually greet your family

Transition from work brain to family brain

### 4. The Last Hour Rule

Last hour before bed: no screens

Blue light messes with sleep

Talk, read, cuddle instead

### 5. No Phones During Conversations

If someone is talking, phones down

Eye contact matters

"Just a second" usually means 20 minutes

## **Rule 11 -25: The Smartphone Boundaries**

### 11. Notification Purge

Turn off ALL non-essential notifications

No social media alerts

No email alerts after work hours

Only calls and texts from family get through

### 12. App Time Limits

iPhone has Screen Time

Android has Digital Well being

Set daily limits for social media

When time's up, it's up

### 13. The Phone Basket

- Decorate a basket together
- Phones go in when entering home
- Creates physical separation

#### 14. The Weekend Digital Detox

- Saturday 9 AM to Sunday 9 PM
- No social media
- No email checking
- Rediscover each other

#### 15. The "I'm Listening" Position

- When partner talks: phone down, screen down
- Actually look at them
- Nod, respond, engage

#### Rule 26 -40: For Parents

#### 26. No Phones During Children's Events

- School plays, sports games, recitals
- Be present for your children
- They notice when you're scrolling

#### 27. Phone -Free Family Time

- Saturday mornings: no devices
- Board games, cooking, outdoor time
- Model good behavior for kids

#### 28. The Parental Control Twist

- Use parental controls... on each other
- Set boundaries together
- Accountability works both ways

## 29. The "Remember When" Game

At dinner: "Remember when we didn't have phones?"

Share stories from childhood

Teach kids about life before smartphones

## 30. Device -Free Bedrooms for Kids Too

Model what you preach

If parents have no phones in bed, kids too

Creates healthy family culture

## Rule 41 -55: Extreme Measures (When Nothing Else Works)

### 41. The Phone Lock box

Literal lock box with timer

Phones locked during family time

\$25 on Amazon, saves marriages

### 42. The Dumb phone Downgrade

Buy a basic phone for evenings/weekends

Can call and text, that's it

Radical but effective

### 43. The Internet Schedule

Router turns off at certain times

No internet = no temptation

Forced connection time

### 44. The Accountability Partner

Friend checks your screen time weekly

Embarrassment motivates change

Works for weight loss, works for phones

### 45. The Professional Help

Therapy for phone addiction

Yes, it's a real addiction

Covered by some insurance

## **CHAPTER 6:- The Conversation Scripts**

### **How to Start "The Phone Talk"**

DON'T SAY: "You're always on that damn phone! You love it more than me!"

DO SAY: "I miss connecting with you. Can we talk about finding more phone -free time together?"

### **The Gentle Approach:**

"I've noticed we're both on our phones a lot lately. I miss our conversations. What if we tried

phone -free dinners this week?"

### **The Direct Approach:**

"Our phone use is affecting our connection. I feel lonely even when we're in the same room. Can we make some changes?"

### **The Humorous Approach:**

"Hey, I think your phone is getting more of your attention than I am. I'm cuter than your phone! And I can make you breakfast!"

When Your Partner Defends Their Phone Use

Common Defenses and How to Respond:

**Defense 1:** "I need it for work!"

Response: "I understand work is important. Can we agree on work -free times? Like after 7 PM and weekends?"

**Defense 2:** "It's how I relax!"

Response: "I want you to relax. What other ways could you relax that we could do together? Walk, massage, watch a movie?"

**Defense 3:** "You're on your phone too!"

Response: "You're right. Let's both make changes. What if we help each other?"

**Defense 4:** "You're controlling!"

Response: "I don't want to control you. I want to connect with you. There's a difference."

## **CHAPTER 7: Success Stories**

### **The TikTok to Transformation Story**

Lagos, Nigeria: "My wife was spending 40 hours a week on TikTok," says Emeka. "Forty hours! That's a full -time job!"

"I didn't attack her. I said, 'What do you love about TikTok?' She said, 'The creativity. The community.'"

"So I said, 'What if we took that creativity offline?' We started a small business together. Making and selling Ankara face masks during COVID. She used her TikTok skills to market it. Now we have a real business that makes real money. And she's on Tik Tok 5 hours a week, not 40."

### **THE GAMING COUPLE WHO LEVELED UP THEIR MARRIAGE**

Houston, Texas: "We were both gamers," says Jamal. "We'd sit in the same room playing different games. Not talking for hours."

"One day our toddler said, 'Mommy, why do you and Daddy love your computers more than me?'" "Ouch." "We sold our gaming PCs. Bought a Nintendo Switch. Now we play cooperative games together. Mario Kart. Overcooked. Games where we work as a team. It's actually brought us closer."

### **The WhatsApp Widow Who Got Her Husband Back**

Abuja, Nigeria: "My husband was in 30 family WhatsApp groups," says Nneka. "Constantly fighting with uncles about politics. Arguing with cousins about family land." "I said, 'Baby, these groups are stealing our peace. And for what? People you see once every five years?'"

"He muted all but three groups. The immediate family ones. The constant buzzing stopped. The stress went down. Our home became peaceful again."



## **CHAPTER 8: The 30 -Day Phone Detox Challenge**

### **Week 1: Awareness**

- Day 1: Check your screen time
- Day 2: Notice when you reach for phone
- Day 3: Delete one social media app
- Day 4: No phone during meals
- Day 5: Charge phone outside bedroom
- Day 6: One hour of phone -free time
- Day 7: Review progress

### **Week 2: Reduction**

- Day 8: Turn off all notifications
- Day 9: Set app time limits
- Day 10: Phone -free morning routine
- Day 11: Leave phone at home for short errands
- Day 12: Read actual book instead of scrolling
- Day 13: Cook together without phones
- Day 14: Go for walk without phones

### **Weeks 3-4: Transformation**

- Daily exercises to replace phone time with connection time
- Learning to be bored together
- Rediscovering conversation
- Building new habits

## **CHAPTER 9: When Phones Are Necessary (The Exceptions)**

Not all phone use is bad. Some is necessary:

1. Long -distance families - Video calls with grandparents
2. Work requirements - Some jobs need availability
3. Medical situations - Doctor on call, sick family member
4. Safety - Navigation, emergencies

The key: Intentional use, not mindless scrolling.

## **CHAPTER 10: Raising Phone -Healthy Children**

Your phone habits your children what's normal.

What children learn: teach

If you scroll during their games, they learn they're not important

If you're always available for work calls, they learn work comes first

If you model balance, they learn balance

### **The 4 Family Phone Rules:**

1. No phones during family activities
2. Devices charged in common area overnight
3. Screen time limits for everyone
4. Regular digital detox days

## **FINAL THOUGHT: YOUR PARTNER IS NOT AN APP**

### **Your partner:**

- ❖ Doesn't refresh with pull -down
- ❖ Can't be muted
- ❖ Doesn't have a "do not disturb" setting (well, maybe sometimes)
- ❖ Can't be updated with new features
- ❖ But can give you something no app can: real love, real connection, real life.

- ❖ Put down the phone. Pick up your partner's hand. The connection you'll make will be better than any Wi-Fi signal.

## **SECTION 4: NIGHT WARS - KICKING, TEETH GRINDING, BLANKET THEFT, HOT/COLD BATTLES**

### **CHAPTER 1: The Battleground Bedroom**

The KungFu Sleeper from Abuja

Marrying Obi was like agreeing to be punched nightly," says Amara, rubbing a still - tender rib. "I didn't know I was marrying a ninja." Obi's nighttime movements had names, Amara cataloged them all:

1. The Roundhouse Kick - Usually around 2 AM, right to her shins
2. The Flailing Arm - Sudden jerks that would hit her face
3. The Full -Body Twitch - Like he was being electrocuted
4. The Sleep Talking - Complete conversations about work projects
5. The Sleep Walking - Once he tried to "file reports" in the bathroom sink

The worst was when he gave me a black eye," Amara says. "He was dreaming about playing football. He elbowed me right in the face. I woke up screaming. He woke up confused. 'Why are you hitting me?' he asked. I WASN'T HITTING HIM!"

They tried everything:

- ❖ Separate blankets (he'd kick them off)
- ❖ Body pillow barrier (he'd kick it over)
- ❖ King -size bed (he'd find her anyway)
- ❖ Sleeping pills (made him kick more violently)

Finally, they saw a sleep specialist in Lagos.

**Diagnosis:** Periodic Limb Movement Disorder.

Treatment: Medication, weighted blanket, and... separate beds pushed together.

"Now we have what I call 'sleepovers,'" Amara says. "We cuddle in his bed until he falls asleep. Then I go to my bed. We hold hands across the gap. In the morning, we cuddle in my bed. It's not conventional, but I have no more bruises."

### **The Blanket Bandit of Toronto**

"David is a blanket thief of Olympic caliber," says his wife Sarah. "I've woken up shivering with him wrapped like a burrito. Just his nose sticking out. Me with nothing." Their bed looked like a war zone every morning:

Sheets pulled out at corners

Blankets piled on his side

Pillows on the floor

Sarah curled in a ball, trying to preserve body heat

"I bought the heaviest, warmest duvet I could find," Sarah says. "He still stole it. I tried clipping it to my side of the bed. He pulled so hard the clips broke."

The solution came from a Swedish couple on Reddit: Two duvets.

"Game changer," Sarah says. "We have a king-size bed with two single duvets. His is blue. Mine is pink. He can burrito himself all he wants. I stay warm. No more 3 AM blanket tug-of-war."

### **The Human Furnace and the Ice Queen**

In Houston, Maria and Carlos had temperature wars.

"I'm always hot," Carlos says. "I sleep naked with a fan blowing directly on me. Maria wears flannel pajamas, socks, and wants three blankets."

"We compromised on 72 degrees," Maria says. "Which means he's sweating and I'm shivering. We'd fight over the thermostat like it controlled nuclear weapons."

Their solution came from a smart thermostat that learns preferences.

"Now the bedroom is 68 degrees at 10 PM when Carlos goes to bed," Maria explains. "At midnight when I come to bed, it's 74. At 2 AM when Carlos gets hot, it goes back to 70. We both sleep better. Technology saved our sleep marriage."

### **The Teeth Grinder from Lagos**

"My husband's teeth grinding sounds like rocks crushing," says Funke. "KRSSCHHH KRSCHHH all night. I recorded it. It sounded like someone chewing gravel."

Chinedu didn't believe her until she played the recording.

"That's horrible!" he said. "Do I really sound like that?"

"Yes! And you're destroying your teeth!"

The dentist confirmed: severe bruxism. Teeth flattened. Jaw pain. Headaches.

**Solution:** A custom night guard.

"Now he looks like a boxer going to sleep," Funke says. "But the noise stopped. And our dentist bills went down."

## **CHAPTER 2: The Science of Sleep Problems**

### **Why People Kick in Their Sleep**

Dr. Adeola Banks, sleep specialist in Abuja, explains:

"Restless Leg Syndrome and Periodic Limb Movement Disorder are real medical conditions. It's not your partner being annoying on purpose. Their brain is sending signals to their limbs to move."

#### **Causes:**

- ❖ Iron deficiency
- ❖ Pregnancy
- ❖ Certain medications
- ❖ Genetics
- ❖ Stress

#### **Treatments:**

- ❖ Iron supplements
- ❖ Prescription medication
- ❖ Weighted blankets

- ❖ Leg massages before bed

### **Why People Grind Their Teeth**

"Bruxism is often stress -related," says Dr. Banks. "Your body holds tension in your jaw. During sleep, it releases as grinding."

#### **Signs you grind your teeth:**

- ❖ Morning jaw pain
- ❖ Headaches
- ❖ Worn -down teeth
- ❖ Your partner complains about noise

#### **Solutions:**

- ❖ Stress reduction
- ❖ Night guard from dentist
- ❖ Jaw relaxation exercises
- ❖ Avoiding caffeine/alcohol before bed

### **Why People Steal Blankets**

"It's about temperature regulation," explains Dr. Banks. "Some people get colder faster. Some overheat. It's biology, not malice."

#### **The blanket thief is usually:**

- ❖ A deeper sleeper
- ❖ Unaware of their actions
- ❖ Just trying to get comfortable

## **CHAPTER 3: Solutions That Work**

### **For the Kicker/Puncher:**

1. Weighted blanket - 15-20 pounds of pressure reduces movement
2. Body pillow barrier - Creates physical separation
3. Separate beds pushed together - Still close, no kicking
4. Medication - For severe cases, see a doctor
5. Exercise before bed - Wears out restless legs

### **For the Blanket Thief:**

1. Two duvets - Scandinavian style, life -changing
2. Sleeping bag - For extreme cases
3. Clip the blanket - To your side of the bed
4. Heavier blanket - Harder to steal
5. Separate top sheets - Under one comforter

### **For Temperature Wars:**

1. Dual -zone electric blanket - His side hot, her side cold
2. Chili-pad - Mattress pad that cools/warms
3. Smart thermostat - Changes temperature through night
4. Different pajamas - He wears shorts, she wears flannel
5. Separate bedrooms - With scheduled sleepovers

### **For Teeth Grinding:**

1. Night guard - From dentist, not drugstore
2. Stress reduction - Meditation, yoga, therapy
3. Jaw exercises - Relax jaw muscles before bed
4. Avoid stimulants - No coffee after 2 PM
5. Massage - Jaw and neck massage

## **CHAPTER 4: When to See a Doctor**

### **See a sleep specialist if:**

- ❖ Kicking causes injury
- ❖ Teeth grinding damages teeth
- ❖ Sleep talking includes violence
- ❖ Sleep walking is dangerous
- ❖ Snoring includes breathing pauses

### **See a dentist if:**

- ❖ Teeth are wearing down
- ❖ Jaw pain in morning
- ❖ Headaches upon waking
- ❖ Your partner complains of grinding noise

## **CHAPTER 5: The Separate Bedroom Solution**

### Breaking the Stigma

"People think separate bedrooms mean your marriage is failing," says Dr. Ngozi Williams. "Actually, sometimes separate bedrooms mean your marriage is smart."

**Historical fact:** Rich couples have always had separate bedrooms. It's a modern idea that couples must share a bed every night.

### How to Do Separate Bedrooms Successfully:

1. Frame it positively - "For better sleep and better marriage"
2. Schedule intimacy - Regular "sleepovers"
3. Keep connecting - Morning coffee, evening talks
4. Make both rooms nice - Not one nice, one dumpy
5. Be flexible - Some nights together, some apart

**Success Story:** The 50 -Year Marriage Saved by Separate Rooms



"John and I have slept separately for 30 years," says Margaret, 78, from London. "And we've been happily married for 50." "We started when his snoring got bad. I moved to the guest room. We slept better. We were nicer to each other during the day." "We have a routine: We cuddle in his bed until 10 PM. Then I go to my room. At 7 AM, he brings me tea in bed. We cuddle and talk." "People thought we were strange. Now our children do it too. Good sleep makes good marriages."

## **CHAPTER 6: Creating a Sleep Sanctuary**

### **The Perfect Bedroom for Two Different Sleepers**

1. Right mattress - Medium firm, minimizes motion transfer
2. Right pillows - Different for each person
3. Temperature control - Smart thermostat or dual controls
4. Light control - Blackout curtains, eye masks
5. Sound control - White noise, earplugs

### **Bedtime Rituals for Better Sleep**

Instead of scrolling in bed:

- ❖ Read actual books
- ❖ Talk about your day
- ❖ Give each other massages
- ❖ Practice gratitude together
- ❖ Plan tomorrow together

The No -Tech Bedroom

- ❖ Charge phones outside bedroom
- ❖ No TV in bedroom

- ❖ Use analog alarm clock
- ❖ Make bedroom for sleep and intimacy only

## **FINAL THOUGHT: SLEEP IS NOT SELFISH**

Good sleep makes you:

- ❖ More patient
- ❖ Less irritable
- ❖ Better able to handle stress
- ❖ More loving
- ❖ Healthier

Investing in good sleep is investing in your relationship.

Sometimes that means separate blankets. Sometimes separate beds. Sometimes a night guard or medication.

Whatever it takes for both of you to wake up rested and ready to love each other.

## **SECTION 5: EMOTIONAL INTIMACY WHEN SEX IS OFF THE MENU**

### **CHAPTER 1: Love Beyond the Bedroom**

#### The Pregnancy That Tested Everything

"When I was pregnant with our twins," says Keisha from Atlanta, "sex was impossible. First trimester: too nauseous. Second trimester: too uncomfortable. Third trimester: too enormous."

"My husband Jamal was understanding. At first. But by month seven, the distance was growing. We were roommates. Co -parents -in-waiting. Not lovers."

"The turning point came when he brought me ice cream at 2 AM. I was crying.

Hormones. Back pain. Fear about being a mother." "He didn't try to fix it. Didn't say, 'It'll be okay.' He just sat with me. Held my hand. Let me cry."

"That moment —him sitting with me in the dark, not wanting anything, just being there that was more intimate than any sex we 'd ever had."

### **The Cancer That Changed Everything**

"Cancer stole our sex life," says David from Toronto. "First the diagnosis. Then the surgery. Then the chemo. Sarah was so sick. So tired." "I missed sex, yes. But more than that, I missed her. Missed us."

"One night, she was too weak to get to the bathroom. I carried her. Helped her. Cleaned her up. Put her back to bed."

"She started crying. 'I'm sorry,' she said. 'I'm not your wife anymore. I'm a patient.'" I held her face. 'You're my wife. Today. Tomorrow. Always. In sickness and in health, remember?'"

"That moment, washing her, caring for her, that was our intimacy. It was different. Deeper. More real than any physical act."

### **The 70 -Year -Old Jamaican Love Story**

"People think old people don't have intimacy ," says Miss Pearl, 74, from Kingston.

"They're wrong. We have better intimacy." "Arthur and I have been married 52 years. Our bodies don't work like they used to. Arthritis. Blood pressure. All that."

"But every morning, he brings me tea in bed. We hold hands and watch the sunrise. We talk about our grandchildren. We remember our youth."

"At night, we rub each other's feet with coconut oil. We pray together. We thank God for another day together." "Sex? That was chapter one of our love story. This the holding, the talking, the caring this is chapter fifty -two. And it's the best chapter."

## **CHAPTER 2: 61 Ways to Feel Close Without Sex**

### **Physical Touch Without Sexual Expectation**

1. The 20 -Second Hug - Science says hugs release bonding hormones
2. Hand Holding - In bed, on couch, walking
3. Foot Rubs - With lotion, no expectation of return
4. Back Scratches - Gentle, soothing

5. Hair Brushing/Playing - Surprisingly intimate
6. Spooning - Just holding, no moving
7. Forehead Kisses - Sweet, loving, non -sexual
8. Hand on Heart - Feeling each other's heartbeat
9. Dancing in Kitchen - Slow, close, no music needed
10. Shared Bath - Just soaking, talking

### **Emotional Connection Practices**

1. Daily Check -In - "How was your heart today?"
2. Gratitude Sharing - "I'm grateful you..."
3. Dream Sharing - "I had a weird dream..."
4. Memory Lane - "Remember when we..."
5. Future Planning - "When we're old, let's..."
6. Book Reading - Read to each other
7. Letter Writing - Old-fashioned love letters
8. Song Dedication - "This song made me think of you"
9. Prayer/Meditation - Together, holding hands
10. Silent Sitting - Just being together quietly

### **Shared Experiences**

1. Cooking Together - One chops, one stirs
2. Gardening - Planting something together
3. Puzzle Building - Cooperation, no talking needed
4. Art Making - Paint, draw, create together
5. Music Making - Even if you're bad at it
6. Walking - Holding hands, no destination
7. Stargazing - Blanket, backyard, wonder
8. Bird Watching - Quiet observation together

9. Photography - Take photos of each other
10. Journalist - Side by side, sharing sometimes

## **CHAPTER 3: Navigating Specific Situations**

### **During Pregnancy**

#### **What helps:**

- ❖ Understanding hormones are real
- ❖ Finding new ways to be close
- ❖ Preparing for baby together
- ❖ Talking about fears and hopes
- ❖ Professional photos of the bump

#### **What hurts:**

- ❖ Pressure for sex
- ❖ Comments about body changes
- ❖ Comparing to "before"
- ❖ Making her feel unattractive

### **After Baby Arrives**

The 6 -Week Rule is a Guideline, Not a Deadline

"After our daughter was born," says Nneka from Lagos, "the doctor said 6 weeks. At 6 weeks, I was exhausted. Breastfeeding. Healing. No sleep."

"Chinedu was patient. He said, 'We have our whole lives. Let's just hold each other.'" "That patience made me want him more when I was ready. Pressure would have pushed me away."

### **Postpartum Intimacy Ideas:**

- Cuddling while baby sleeps on chest
- Holding hands during night feeds
- Showering together (just to wash, not sex)
- Quick kisses when passing baby
- "You're a great mother" compliments

### **During Illness**

Cancer, Surgery, Chronic Illness

"The key," says Dr. Adeola, "is separating caregiving from partnership. You're still husband and wife, not just patient and caregiver."

### **Ways to maintain intimacy during illness:**

1. Date nights in - Even if just special dinner in bed
2. Non-sexual touch - Hand holding, hair stroking
3. Shared laughter - Comedy movies, funny stories
4. Dreaming together - Planning for after recovery
5. Rituals - Daily tea, evening prayer, morning greeting

### **During Stressful Times**

Job Loss, Financial Stress, Family Crises "When I lost my job," says Emeka from Abuja, "I felt less of a man. I didn't want to touch my wife. Felt like I didn't deserve her." "My wife Ngozi was smart. She didn't push for sex. She pushed for connection." "She'd say, 'Let's just hold each other.' Or 'Tell me how you're feeling.' Or 'We'll get through this together.'"

"That emotional intimacy kept us strong. When the stress passed, the physical intimacy returned naturally."

## **CHAPTER 4: When One Partner Wants Sex and the Other Doesn't**

### The Desire Gap

"This is common," says Dr. Ngozi Williams. "One partner has higher libido. This becomes a problem when it's not talked about."

### **How to Talk About It**

The higher -desire partner should:

Express feelings without pressure

"I miss feeling close to you" not "We never have sex"

Suggest alternatives to intercourse

Be understanding of stress/tiredness

The lower -desire partner should:

- ❖ Acknowledge the other's feelings
- ❖ "I know this is hard for you too"
- ❖ Offer non -sexual intimacy
- ❖ Be honest about reasons
- ❖ Get medical help if needed

### **Compromise Solutions**

1. Scheduled intimacy - Not just sex, any intimacy
2. Expanded definition of sex - Oral, manual, etc.
3. Self-pleasure with partner present - Still connection
4. Focus on quality over quantity - One great connection vs. three meh ones

## **CHAPTER 5: Rebuilding Intimacy After Dry Spells**

### The 30-Day Intimacy Challenge

#### **Week 1: Reconnecting**

Day 1 -7: Daily 20 -second hug

No pressure for sex

Just physical re-connection

### **Week 2: Talking**

Day 8 -14: 15 minutes of uninterrupted talking daily

No phones, no TV

Just listening

### **Week 3: Touch**

Day 15 -21: Non -sexual touch daily

Massage, hand holding, cuddling

No expectation of sex

### **Week 4: Exploration**

Day 22 -30: Explore what feels good now

Bodies and desires may have changed

Communicate openly

## **CHAPTER 6: When Medical Help is Needed**

### **Signs to See a Doctor:**

#### **For women:**

- ❖ Pain during sex
- ❖ Lack of desire with distress
- ❖ Hormonal issues
- ❖ Menopause symptoms affecting intimacy

#### **For men:**

Erectile dysfunction

Low testosterone



Performance anxiety  
Medication side effects

**For both:**

History of trauma affecting intimacy  
Body image issues preventing closeness  
Religious/cultural shame about sex

**Types of Professionals Who Can Help:**

1. Gynecologist/Urologist - Physical issues
2. Endocrinologist - Hormonal issues
3. Sex Therapist - Psychological issues
4. Marriage Counselor - Relationship issues
5. Pelvic Floor Therapist - Pain issues

**FINAL THOUGHT: INTIMACY IS A SPECTRUM**

Sex is one point on the intimacy spectrum. But there are many points:

- ❖ Eye contact across a room
- ❖ Inside jokes no one else gets
- ❖ Holding hands during hard news
- ❖ Knowing how they take their tea
- ❖ Finishing each other's sentences
- ❖ Sitting in comfortable silence
- ❖ Caring for each other when sick

These moments of connection —these are the foundation of lasting love.

The couples who last decades aren't necessarily having the most sex. They're having the most real moments. The most true connection. The most "I see you and I'm here with you" experiences.

That's available to every couple, regardless of age, health, or circumstance.

Start with a 20 -second hug today. See where it leads.

## **SECTION 6: HOW TO SAVE A COMPLETELY DEAD BEDROOM & DYING MARRIAGE**

### **When the Love Has Almost Died**

#### **The Couple Who Had Packed Bags in Abuja**

Nneka and Emeka had two suitcases by the door. One for him. One for her. They hadn't touched each other in 11 months . Hadn't said "I love you" in 8 months. Hadn't shared a meal without the TV on in 2 years.

"We were roommates who happened to share children," Nneka says, staring at her tea. "We slept back -to-back, literally and emotionally. The only time we touched was passing the salt." The breaking point was small. Of course it was small. It always is. "I made his favorite soup," Nneka continues. "Egusi with goat meat. He ate it. Said nothing.

Didn't say thank you. Didn't notice I'd spent 4 hours making it."

"I watched him eat. Watched him get up. Watched him walk to the TV without even looking at me. And something in me broke. Not dramatically. Quietly. Like a glass cracking."

She packed a bag that night. He packed his the next morning. They agreed: After Christmas. For the children. Then they would separate.

#### **29 Couples Who Came Back from the Brink**

1. Houston, Texas: "We hadn't had sex in 3 years," says Jamal. "Keisha slept in the guest room. We communicated through Post -it notes. 'Your mother called.' 'Water bill due.'"

"The turnaround started when our dog died. Buster, our golden retriever. We both cried. Held each other while we buried him in the backyard. That shared grief... it reminded us we could still feel something together."

2. London, UK: "Sarah had an emotional affair," David admits. "Not physical. But she was texting another man. Sharing things with him s he hadn't shared with me in years." "Confrontation. Tears. Therapy. The therapist said something that changed everything: 'The affair isn't the problem. It's a symptom. What was missing that she went looking for?'"

3. Accra, Ghana: "We were business partn ers, not spouses," says Abena. "Kofi ran the construction company. I ran the home. We met quarterly to discuss finances and children's school fees. That was our marriage."

"What saved us? COVID lockdown. Trapped together for 3 months. No escape. We had to talk. Had to remember who we were before the business, before the children, before the responsibilities."

### **The Science: Why Marriages Die Slowly**

Dr. Chinedu Okoro, marriage researcher in Lagos, explains:

"Marriages don't die in earthquakes. They die in drips. The 'drip method' of marital destruction:

1. Neglect Drip - Not noticing haircut, not asking about day
2. Criticism Drip - 'You always...' 'You never...'
3. Defensiveness Drip - 'It's not my fault!'
4. Contempt Drip - Eye rolling, sarcasm, disgust
5. Stonewalling Drip - Silent treatment, withdrawal

"Each drip seems small. But after 10,000 drips? The foundation is washed away."

## **CHAPTER 2: The 21 -Day Miracle Plan**

### **Phase 1: The Ceasefire (Days 1 -7)**

#### **Rule 1: No Criticism**

- ❖ No "you always"
- ❖ No "you never"

- ❖ If you must complain: "I feel emotion when specific thing happens"

### **Rule 2: One Kind Act Daily**

- ❖ Make tea
- ❖ Pack lunch
- ❖ Fill gas tank
- ❖ Small, no -strings -attached kindness

### **Rule 3: 15 Minutes of Civil Conversation**

- ❖ No phones
- ❖ No TV
- ❖ Talk about anything but marriage problems
- ❖ Weather, news, memories, dreams

### **Day 1 -3 Results from Real Couples:**

- ❖ "We managed one civil conversation about the weather"
- ❖ "I made his coffee. He said thank you. Small win"
- ❖ "We went 24 hours without fighting. A record"

### **Phase 2: Re-connection (Days 8 -14)**

#### **Rule 4: Daily Appreciation**

"Thank you for..."

"I noticed you..."

"I appreciate..."

#### **Rule 5: Shared Activity**

Cook together

Walk together

Watch one episode of something together

No talking required, just shared experience

### **Rule 6: Physical Touch Without Expectation**

20-second hug

Hand holding

Goodnight kiss on cheek

NO SEX EXPECTATION

### **Day 8 -14 Results:**

"We held hands during our walk. First time in years"

"She said 'I appreciate you working hard for our family.' I cried"

"We cooked jollof rice together. Didn't burn it. Didn't fight"

### **Phase 3: Rebuilding (Days 15 -21)**

#### **Rule 7: Vulnerability Share**

"One thing I'm struggling with..."

"One thing I miss about us..."

"One hope I have..."

#### **Rule 8: Future Dreaming**

"When we're old..."

"Next year, I'd like us to..."

"Remember when we used to..."

#### **Rule 9: Intimacy Exploration**

NOT necessarily sex

What does connection look like now?

What feels good? What doesn't?

Communicate without pressure

## **Day 15 -21 Results:**

"We talked about our honeymoon. Actually smiled"

"He admitted he's scared of failing as a husband. I admitted I am too"

"We cuddled on the couch. Just cuddled. It was enough"

## **CHAPTER 3: The Love Letters That Broke Through**

The Letter That Made a Grown Man Cry in Ikeja Mall

"Dear Emeka,

I'm writing this in Chicken Republic while you're getting the car washed. We haven't spoken properly in months. But I remember...

I remember the boy who borrowed his friend's car to take me on our first date. Who was so nervous he drove past my house three times.

I remember the man who held my hair back when I had morning sickness with Chisom. Who whispered, 'We're in this together' even though it was my body doing all the work. I remember the father who cried when he first held Ada. Who promised her, 'I'll always protect you.'

I don't know where that man went. But I miss him. And I miss us. Love, Nneka"

"I read it in the mall food court," Emeka says, tears in his eyes even now. "I cried like a baby. People stared. I didn't care. She remembered. She still saw me under all the mess."

How to Write a Breakthrough Letter

### **Formula:**

1. Remember - Specific positive memory
2. Acknowledge - Current pain/distance
3. Hope - Wish for re-connection
4. Commit - One small action you'll take

### **Example:**

"Remember when we used to [specific memory]? Lately I've noticed [current distance]. I

wish we could [hope]. I'm going to try [commitment]."

### **What NOT to write:**

Blame

Lists of complaints

Ultimatums

Sarcasm

## **CHAPTER 4: When Therapy is Needed**

### Signs You Need Professional Help

1. Communication is impossible - Every conversation becomes a fight
2. Trust is completely broken - Infidelity, lying, betrayal
3. Contempt is present - Eye rolling, name calling, disgust
4. One/both are emotionally checked out - Don't care anymore
5. Considering/pursuing separation - Bags are packed

### **Types of Marriage Help Available**

#### 1. Marriage Counseling (Most Common)

Both partners attend

Neutral third party

Teaches communication skills

8-12 sessions average

Cost: ₦20,000 - ₦50,000 per session in Nigeria

#### 2. Individual Therapy

Each works on personal issues affecting marriage

Childhood trauma

Personal growth

Sometimes more effective than couples therapy

#### 4. Intensive Marriage Retreats

Weekend or week -long

Intensive work

Removes daily distractions

Cost: ₦500,000+ but can save marriage

#### 4. Religious Counseling

Through church/mosque

Spiritual perspective

Often free or low -cost

May include prayer, scripture

#### How to Suggest Therapy Without Starting a Fight

##### **DO:**

"I think we could use some help communicating better"

"I want us to be happier together"

"Can we try a few sessions and see if it helps?"

##### **DON'T:**

"You need therapy!"

"Our marriage is broken because of you"

"My friend's husband went and he's fixed now"

#### **What to Expect in First Session**

1. History taking - How you met, timeline
2. Identifying problems - What brings you in
3. Setting goals - What would success look like?
4. Homework - Usually communication exercises



## 5. Next steps - Schedule, commitment

### **CHAPTER 5: Radical Interventions for Radical Problems**

#### The 30 -Day Separation That Saved a Marriage

"Sometimes you need space to miss each other," says Dr. Williams.

**Case Study:** David and Sarah, Toronto

"We separated for 30 days," Sarah explains. "Not legally. Just... space. He stayed with his brother. I stayed home with kids."

"Rules: No contact for first 2 weeks. Then one phone call per week. No seeing each other." "The first week was relief. The second week was... quiet. The third week... I missed him. The way he makes tea. The way he laughs at his own jokes. Even the way he leaves socks everywhere." "At our first meeting after 30 days? We held hands for an hour. Just held hands. Talked like we were dating again. The space had made us appreciate what we had."

#### The "Start Over" Strategy

##### **Step 1: Formal ending**

- Write down what's ending

- Have small ceremony (even just verbal)

- Acknowledge pain, disappointment

##### **Step 2: Separation period**

- 30-90 days minimal contact

- Individual work

- Clarify what you want

##### **Step 3: Dating again**

- Literally date

- Start from beginning

- No assuming old roles

## **Step 4: New marriage**

New commitments

New patterns

Learned from past mistakes

## **CHAPTER 6: When Sex Has Completely Stopped**

### **The 6 -Month Dry Spell**

"No sex for 6 months," says Kofi from Accra. "Then 12. Then 18. By 2 years, we were sleeping in separate rooms. By 3 years, we were basically siblings raising children together."

### **Common causes of dead bedrooms:**

1. Resentment - Unresolved anger kills desire
2. Body issues - Weight gain, aging, health problems
3. Performance anxiety - Pressure makes it worse
4. Medical issues - Hormones, medications, pain
5. Relationship issues - Not feeling connected

## **The Sex Reboot Protocol**

### **Week 1 -2: Sensation Focus**

No genital touch allowed

Explore other touch

Back rubs, foot massages, hair brushing

Learn to enjoy touch without pressure

### **Week 3 -4: Communication**

Talk about what feels good

Use hand signals during touch

Green = more, Yellow = slow down, Red = stop

Practice asking for what you want

## **Week 5 -6: Gradual Reintroduction**

Start with mutual masturbation

Then oral sex

Then intercourse with no goal

Focus on pleasure, not orgasm

## **Week 7 -8: Integration**

Regular intimate time

Mix sensual and sexual

Keep communicating

Celebrate progress

## **CHAPTER 7: When Trust is Broken**

After Infidelity: The Long Road Back

Case Study: Chidinma and Tunde, Lagos

"He had an affair with his secretary," Chidinma says flatly. "6 months. I found texts. Confronted him. He admitted."

### **Phase 1: Crisis (First 3 Months )**

All contact with affair person cut immediately

Complete transparency with phones/location

Daily check -ins about feelings

Professional help mandatory

### **Phase 2: Understanding (Months 4 -12)**

Why did it happen? (Not excuse, but understanding)

What was missing in marriage?

Individual work on both sides

### **Phase 3: Rebuilding (Year 2 -3)**

New patterns

New transparency

Gradual rebuilding of trust

Forgiveness (not forgetting)

### **Phase 4: New Normal (Year 4+)**

Marriage is different but can be stronger

Scar tissue is stronger than original skin

Continued vigilance

Appreciation for second chance

### **The Transparency Rules After Betrayal**

1. Open device policy - Passwords shared, devices open
2. Location sharing - Always on
3. Check -in calls - When apart more than 2 hours
4. Social media transparency - Friends/followers known
5. Financial transparency - All accounts visible

"This feels extreme," says Dr. Williams. "But trust is like a shattered vase. You must gather every piece. Glue carefully. The cracks will show forever, but it can hold water again."

## **CHAPTER 8: Practical Tools for Rebuilding**

The Daily Connection Checklist

### **Morning (5 minutes):**

- ❖ Eye contact and "good morning"
- ❖ One thing you appreciate about partner

- ❖ Plan to connect later

### **Evening (15 minutes):**

- ❖ Put phones away
- ❖ Ask: "How was your heart today?"
- ❖ Share one positive from day
- ❖ Physical touch (hug, hand hold)

### **Weekly (1 hour):**

- ❖ Date night (home or out)
- ❖ Check -in about relationship
- ❖ Plan for upcoming week
- ❖ Fun activity together
- ❖ The "Fight Fair" Rules Poster

Many couples put this on fridge:

### **OUR FIGHTING RULES**

1. No name calling
2. No "always/never"
3. Take breaks if needed
4. One issue at a time
5. Seek solution, not victory
6. Repair attempt within 24 hours

### **The Appreciation Jar**

Empty jar on kitchen counter

Small papers nearby

Write appreciation, drop in jar

Read together weekly

"I saw you playing with the kids"

"Thank you for making dinner"

"I love your laugh"

## **CHAPTER 9: When It's Time to Let Go**

Signs It Might Be Over

1. Abuse - Physical, emotional, verbal
2. Unwillingness to change - Despite pain, won't try
3. Repeated infidelity - Pattern, not mistake
4. Complete emotional disconnection - Don't care anymore
5. Different life goals - Can't compromise

### **How to Separate with Dignity**

#### **If children are involved:**

1. Tell children together - Age-appropriate explanation
2. Unified front - Never badmouth other parent
3. Consistency - Similar rules in both homes
4. Therapy for children - Helps adjustment

#### **Practical steps:**

1. Consult lawyer - Know rights
2. Financial planning - Separate accounts
3. Living arrangements - Who stays? Who goes?
4. Support system - Friends, family, therapy

When Separation Leads to Reconciliation

"About 15% of separated couples reconcile," says Dr. Williams. "Often the space shows them what they're losing."

### **Signs reconciliation might work:**

Both do individual work during separation

Identify and address original problems

Want to come back for right reasons (love, not convenience)

Willing to create new relationship, not return to old patterns

### **FINAL THOUGHT: THE MARRIAGE IS WORTH SAVING IF...**

Dr. Williams' final checklist:

Your marriage might be save able if:

- ❖ There was once real love
- ❖ You share values/goals
- ❖ You're willing to try
- ❖ No abuse is present
- ❖ You can remember good times

### **Try this first:**

1. One month of daily kindness
2. Professional help (3 sessions minimum)
3. Radical honesty about what you want
4. Willingness to change yourself first

**Remember:** Every marriage has seasons. Winter feels eternal when you're in it. But spring can come. Often does. Sometimes you just need the right tools to thaw the ground.

## SECTION 7: WHEN YOUR PARTNER IS EMOTIONALLY CLOSED

### CHAPTER 1: The Nigerian Bank Vault Syndrome

"I'm Fine" While the House Burns

Chidi was a successful banker in Lagos. Sharp suits. Firm handshake. Knew everything about interest rates, nothing about his own feelings.

"Ask him how he's feeling," his wife Amara says, "and he says, 'I'm fine.' The company could be collapsing, he'd say, 'I'm fine.' Our child could be in hospital, 'I'm fine.'"

"It's not that he doesn't feel," she continues. "I've seen him cry once —when his father died. But he cried alone, in the garage, where no one could see. Then washed his face, came inside, said, 'I'm fine.'"

The African Man's Emotional Dilemma:

Cultural training: "Men don't cry"

Family expectation: "Be strong"

Religious teaching: "God will handle it"

Social pressure: "Don't show weakness"

**Result:** A man who can run a bank but can't name his emotions. Who can solve complex problems but can't say, "I'm scared." Who can provide everything except emotional presence.

The Silent Husbands of Different Cultures

Japan: "My husband speaks 100 words a day," says Yuki from Tokyo. "50 at work. 50 to me. Mostly 'yes,' 'no,' 'dinner ready?' We've been married 20 years. I know his salary, his blood type, his shoe size. I don't know his dreams."

Finland: "In Finland, we say silence is golden," says Liisa from Helsinki. "My husband and I can sit for hours without speaking. It's comfortable. But sometimes... I wonder what he's thinking. What he's feeling. If he's happy."

America: "American men talk about sports, work, politics," says Jennifer from Chicago. "Feelings? Vulnerability? That's for therapy. My husband can analyze football plays for hours. Ask him how he feels about our marriage? 'It's fine.'"



## **The Cost of Emotional Distance**

### **What happens when one partner is closed:**

1. The other becomes a detective - "What does that sigh mean?"
2. Resentment builds - "I share everything, you share nothing"
3. Intimacy dies - Can't be close to someone you don't know
4. Parenting suffers - Children learn emotional avoidance
5. Health problems - Stress with no outlet

## **CHAPTER 2: Why People Close Up**

### Childhood Programming

#### **Case Study:** David, Toronto

"My father's emotional range was: angry, not angry," David says. "That's it. Happy? Not angry. Sad? Not angry. Scared? Angry."

"So I learned: Emotions are dangerous. Showing feelings is weak. Better to be quiet. Better to be 'fine.'"

"Now my wife wants me to 'open up.' I don't know how. I don't have the vocabulary. I feel things... but I can't name them. It's like being asked to describe colors when you're colorblind."

#### **Cultural Expectations**

In Nigeria: "Real men don't cry" isn't just a saying —it's a cultural mandate.

Research shows: Nigerian boys as young as 5 are told, "Stop crying! Are you a girl?" By 15, they've learned emotional expression = weakness. By 25, they're emotionally constipated.

But traditional wisdom also says: "The tortoise carries its house on its back."  
Meaning:

Everyone carries their burdens. The wise ask for help carrying sometimes.

## **Fear of Vulnerability**

The fear hierarchy:

1. Fear of appearing weak - "She'll lose respect"
2. Fear of burdening - "She has her own problems"
3. Fear of conflict - "If I'm honest, we might fight"
4. Fear of rejection - "What if she doesn't understand?"
5. Fear of feeling - "If I start, I might not stop"

## **CHAPTER 3: How to Open a Closed Partner**

### **Strategy 1: Create Safety**

#### **What NOT to do:**

"You never share your feelings!"

"Why are you so closed off?"

"My friend's husband tells her everything!"

#### **What To do:**

"I want to understand you better"

"When you're ready, I'm here"

"No judgment, just listening"

### **The Safe Space Rules:**

1. No interruptions - Let them finish
2. No advice - Unless asked
3. No criticism - Of feelings
4. No comparing - To others
5. Thank them - For sharing

### **Strategy 2: Ask Better Questions**

Closed questions get closed answers:

"How was your day?" → "Fine"

"Are you okay?" → "Yes"

Open questions get open answers:

"What was the best part of your day?"

"What's on your mind lately?"

"If you could change one thing about work, what?"

"What are you looking forward to?"

The Feeling Wheel Approach:

Print a feeling wheel (available online). Ask: "Which of these are you feeling today?" Makes it

easier for those who struggle to name emotions.

**Strategy 3:** Side -by-Side Talking

For many men (and some women):

Eye-to-eye feels confrontational

Side-by-side feels safer

**Try:**

Talking in the car

Walking together

Sitting on porch looking out

Doing activity together (cooking, gardening)

**Case Study:** Kofi and Abena, Accra

"He wouldn't talk at dinner table," Abena says. "Too much eye contact. Too intense."

"So we started walking. Every evening, around our neighborhood. No eye contact. Just walking. Side by side."

"And he started talking. About work stress. About his mother's health. About his dreams for our children. The words flowed when we were moving forward together."

#### Strategy 4: Use Their Language

If they're practical: -

Don't ask: "How do you feel?"

Ask: "What do you think about...?"

"Thinking" is safer than "feeling" for some

If they're problem -solvers:

"What's the biggest challenge you're facing?"

"How can we solve this together?"

Framing as "problem to solve" rather than "feelings to share"

If they're action -oriented:

"What do you need right now?" (Space? Help? Quiet?)

Sometimes action precedes emotion

### **CHAPTER 4: When the Closed Partner is the Woman**

#### The Silent Wife Syndrome

Not all closed partners are men. Women can be emotionally closed too, often for different reasons.

#### **Case Study:** Nkechi, Abuja

"After my third miscarriage," Nkechi whispers, "I stopped talking. Stopped feeling. It hurt too much."

"My husband wanted me to 'open up.' But every time I tried, I cried. And crying felt... weak. Out of control."

"So I went silent. Made dinner. Cleaned house. Went to work. Smiled. But inside? Frozen."

### **Reasons women close up:**

1. Trauma - Past abuse, loss
2. Depression - Emotional numbness
3. Cultural pressure - "Be strong woman"
4. Resentment - Too much to say, so says nothing
5. Self-protection - Been hurt when vulnerable before

### **How to Reach a Closed Woman**

Different approach needed:

1. Patience - Don't pressure
2. Professional help - Therapy often needed
3. Non-verbal connection - Touch, acts of service
4. Safety - Prove you won't use her vulnerability against her
5. Time - Healing can't be rushed

## **CHAPTER 5: Tools for Emotional Literacy**

The Feeling Vocabulary List

Many closed partners simply lack emotional vocabulary.

Basic feelings list to share:

Happy, Sad, Angry, Scared

Tired, Stressed, Overwhelmed

Proud, Excited, Hopeful

Lonely, Confused, Peaceful

Exercise: At dinner, each shares: "Today I felt [one feeling] when [situation]."

### The Scale Method

For those who can't describe feelings:

"On a scale of 1 -10, how stressed are you?"

"On a scale of 1 -10, how happy are you with us?"

"On a scale of 1 -10, how tired are you?"

Numbers feel safer than words for analytical people.

### The Journal Bridge

Sometimes writing is easier than speaking.

Try:

Shared journal

Leave notes for each other

Text feelings when apart

Email as communication method

### Case Study: David and Keisha, Houston

"He couldn't say 'I'm overwhelmed' out loud," Keisha says. "But he could text it. So we started texting feelings during day. 'Work stressful, 8/10.' 'Missing you, wish home.'"

"Then at night, we'd read texts together. Talk about them. The text gave him time to formulate. Space to be vulnerable without immediate response."

## **CHAPTER 6: When to Accept the Silence**

### The 40/60 Rule

Dr. Williams suggests: "Aim for 40% more openness than currently. Not 100%. Not complete transformation overnight."

**Realistic expectations:**

If he shares 0% now, 40% is huge progress

If she shares only practical matters, adding some feelings is success

Small steps, celebrated

**Different Love Languages**

Some show love through:

Acts of service (fixing things, working hard)

Gifts (providing, buying things)

Quality time (being present, even if silent)

Physical touch (hugs, sex, closeness)

Words of affirmation (compliments, verbal love)

If your partner is closed verbally but shows love in other ways:

Appreciate what they DO give

Don't demand they give in your preferred language only

Meet in middle

**The Comfortable Silence**

Not all silence is bad. Some couples have comfortable silence —peaceful coexistence without constant talking.

**How to tell if silence is healthy or harmful:**

Healthy: Both feel connected during silence

Harmful: One feels lonely, ignored during silence

Healthy: Can break silence easily when needed

Harmful: Breaking silence feels dangerous

Healthy: Silence by choice

Harmful: Silence by default/fear

## **CHAPTER 7: Professional Help for Emotional Blockage**

When Therapy is Needed

### **Signs:**

Complete emotional shutdown

History of trauma

Depression/anxiety symptoms

Affecting work/health

Partner at breaking point

### **Types of Therapy That Help**

#### **1. Individual Therapy**

For the closed partner

Safe space to explore feelings

Learn emotional vocabulary

Process past trauma

#### **2. Couples Therapy**

With therapist as translator

Teaches communication

Creates safe space for sharing

Therapist models emotional expression

#### **3. Men's Groups**



For men specifically  
See other men being vulnerable  
Reduces shame  
Peer support

#### 4. Art/Music Therapy

Non-verbal expression  
Good for those who struggle with words  
Creative outlet for emotions

### **CHAPTER 8: Success Stories**

#### The Banker Who Learned to Feel

"After 20 years of marriage," says Amara from Lagos, "Chidi finally cried in front of me.

Not just tears. Sobbing. His father's death anniversary. He broke."

"I held him. Said nothing. Just held."

"After, he said, 'I'm sorry.' I said, 'For what? For being human?'"

"Now? He's not suddenly poetic. Not sharing sonnets. But he'll say, 'Work was hard today. I feel tired.' Or 'I miss you when you travel.'"

"Small sentences. Huge progress."

#### The Finnish Silence That Found Words

"Liisa and I went to couples therapy," says Mikko from Helsinki. "The therapist asked,

'What do you love about each other?'"

"I said, 'She's reliable.' Therapist said, 'That's what you appreciate. What do you LOVE?'"

"I struggled. Finally: 'When she makes coffee in morning... the way she hums... it makes

me feel... home.'"

"Liisa cried. 'You notice my humming?'"

"Now we say one feeling per day. Just one. 'Today I feel proud when...' 'Today I felt nervous about...' Small. Consistent. Life -changing."

## **FINAL THOUGHT: THE JOURNEY OF A THOUSAND MILES**

Opening a closed partner is like:

Teaching a new language

Thawing frozen ground

Building a bridge over a canyon

### **It requires:**

Patience (lots)

Safety (absolute)

Small steps (celebrated)

Professional help (when needed)

Appreciation for progress (not perfection)

Remember: The strongest steel is forged in the hottest fire. The deepest connection is often built after the hardest opening.

Sometimes the most profound "I love you" is not in the grand declaration, but in the quiet

"I'm scared" finally spoken aloud after years of silence.

## **SECTION 8: FIGHTING WITHOUT BECOMING ENEMIES**

### **CHAPTER 1: Wisdom from 50 -Year Marriages**

The Jamaican Grandmother's Secret

Miss Pearl, 78 years old, married 55 years, Kingston, Jamaica:

"Arthur and I have had one rule for fighting since 1968: No going to bed angry. Not 'try not to.' Not 'usually don't.' NO going to bed angry."

"But here's the secret," she continues, eyes twinkling. "The rule isn't 'solve it before bed.'"

The rule is 'touch before bed.'"

"Maybe we're still mad. Still disagree. But we hold hands. We say, 'I love you even though I'm mad.' We kiss goodnight. Even if it's a quick, hard kiss."

"The problem waits. The love doesn't."

The Indian Aunties' Collective Wisdom

A group of Indian grandmothers in Toronto share their rules:

Mrs. Patel, married 52 years: "Never fight hungry. Always eat first. Hunger makes everything worse."

Mrs. Sharma, married 48 years: "No fighting in bedroom. Bedroom is for peace. For intimacy. Take arguments to kitchen. To living room. Not to bed."

Mrs. Gupta, married 54 years: "Use your mother tongue when really angry. If you're going to say something harsh, say it in Hindi/Urdu/Punjabi. Gives you split second to think. And your English -speaking children won't understand!"

The German Opa's Precision Fighting

Hans, 82, married 58 years, Hamburg (now in Houston):

"In Germany, we are precise. So our fighting is precise. We have Fighting Rules posted on fridge:

1. One issue at a time (No bringing up 1987!)
2. Facts, not feelings (First state facts, then feelings)
3. Timer (Each gets 5 minutes uninterrupted)
4. Solution focus (What will fix this?)
5. Repair (How will we reconnect after?)

"Seems clinical," Hans admits. "But it works. 58 years works."

## **CHAPTER 2: The Anatomy of a Healthy Fight**

### **Stage 1: The Spark**

What it is: The trigger. The wet towel on bed. The forgotten anniversary. The critical comment.

Healthy response: "When you leave towels on the bed, I feel frustrated because I have to remake the bed."

Unhealthy response: "You're such a slob! You never think of anyone but yourself!"

### **Stage 2: The Escalation**

What happens: Voices rise. Past grievances surface. Defensiveness appears.

Healthy management: "I need a break. Let's pause for 20 minutes and come back."

Unhealthy management: Screaming match. Name calling. Stonewalling.

### **Stage 3: The Resolution**

What needs to happen: Understanding. Compromise. Repair.

**Healthy resolution:** "I understand you forget because you're tired. Can you try to remember? Can I help by putting a hamper here?"

**Unhealthy resolution:** Silent treatment. "Fine, whatever." No real solution.

### **Stage 4: The Repair**

The most important stage: Reconnecting after conflict.

Healthy repair: "I'm sorry I yelled. I love you." Hug. Kiss. Connection.

Unhealthy repair: Pretend it didn't happen. Cold distance. Resentment.

## **CHAPTER 3: The Exact Words to Use**

Instead of "You" Statements, Use "I" Statements

Formula: "I feel [emotion] when [specific behavior] happens because [reason]."

Examples:

"I feel hurt when you're on your phone during dinner because I want to connect with you."

"I feel overwhelmed when the house is messy because I just cleaned it."

"I feel worried when you come home late without calling because I care about your safety."

The Magic Question

After argument, ask: "What do you need from me right now?"

Not: "What's wrong with you?"

But: "What do you need?"

Possible answers:

"I need space to cool down"

"I need you to listen without solving"

"I need a hug"

"I need you to acknowledge my feelings"

The Repair Attempt Phrases

Dr. John Gottman's research found these phrases save marriages:

1. "I'm sorry." (Simple, powerful)
2. "You're right about that part." (Partial agreement)
3. "I can see why you'd feel that way." (Validation)
4. "Help me understand." (Curiosity, not defensiveness)
5. "This is important to you, so it's important to me." (Prioritizing relationship)

## **CHAPTER 4: Cultural Fighting Styles**

Nigerian Fighting Style

Observations from couples in Lagos:

**Pros:**

- Passionate
- Everything out in open
- Quick to anger, quick to forgive
- Often includes humor even in fighting

**Cons:**

- Can include extended family ("Your mother said...")
- Sometimes too public (neighbors hear)
- Can escalate quickly

Nigerian Grandmother's Advice: "Fight in English if educated, vernacular if not. But never mix. Mixing means you're really angry!"

American Fighting Style

**Observations from couples across USA:****Pros:**

- Direct
- Solution -focused
- Often use "I feel" statements
- Willing to get professional help

**Cons:**

- Can be overly clinical
- Sometimes avoid conflict too long
- Individualistic focus (my needs vs. our needs)

Canadian Fighting Style

Observations from Toronto/Vancouver:

**Pros:**

Polite even when angry  
"Sorry" used frequently  
Good at compromise

**Cons:**

Sometimes too polite (feelings buried)  
Conflict avoidance  
Hard to tell when really upset

**Blended Cultural Wisdom**

Best practices from all cultures:

Nigerian passion + American directness + Canadian politeness  
Fight with heart, but with respect  
Be clear, but be kind  
Solve problem, but preserve relationship

**CHAPTER 5: What NOT to Do in a Fight**

The Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse (Gottman's Research)

**1. Criticism**

Not: "You never help with dishes!"  
But: "I'd appreciate help with dishes tonight."

**2. Contempt**

Not: Eye rolling, sarcasm, disgust  
But: Respect even when disagreeing

### 3. Defensiveness

Not: "It's not my fault!"

But: "Tell me more about your perspective."

### 4. Stonewalling

Not: Silent treatment, withdrawal

But: "I need a break, but I'll come back to this."

### Other Fight -Killers to Avoid

#### 1. The Kitchen Sink

Don't throw in every past grievance

One issue at a time

Solve today's problem, not last year's

#### 2. The Character Assassination

"You're lazy/stupid/selfish"

Attack behavior, not character

"Leaving dishes out" vs. "You're a slob"

#### 3. The Ultimatum

"Do this or I'm leaving!"

Creates fear, not cooperation

Rarely leads to real change

#### 5. The Public Humiliation

Fighting in front of others

Children, friends, family



Damages dignity, hard to recover

5. The Never -Ending Fight

Same fight for years

Means never really solving

Consider professional help

## **CHAPTER 6: Making Up Matters More Than Fighting**

### The 24 -Hour Repair Rule

From couples married 40+ years: "If you can't solve it in 24 hours, you're not trying right."

Repair attempts that work:

1. The Touch Attempt

Hand on shoulder

Pinky finger hook

Foot touching under table

Non-verbal "I'm still here"

2. The Humor Attempt

Inside joke

Funny memory

Self-deprecation

"We're being silly, let's stop"

3. The Service Attempt

Make tea/coffee for them

Do their chore

Small kindness

"I care even when mad"

## 5. The Verbal Attempt

"I'm sorry"

"I love you"

"This isn't worth losing us over"

"You're more important than being right"

## The Making -Up Ritual

Many long -term couples have rituals:

Case Study: David and Sarah, London (married 42 years)

"After a fight," Sarah says, "David makes tea. Not just any tea. Proper British tea. Tea bag in mug. Hot water. Milk last. Sugar if I want."

"He brings it. Doesn't say anything. Just puts it near me."

"That's my signal. The fight is over. The love is back."

"Then we drink tea. Sometimes talk. Sometimes just sit. But the fight is done."

## **CHAPTER 7: Teaching Children Healthy Conflict**

What Children Learn from Your Fights

### **They learn:**

How to handle disagreement

Whether conflict is scary or normal

How to make up after anger

Whether love survives disagreement

## Healthy Conflict Modeling

### **What to do in front of children:**

Disagree respectfully

Use calm voices

Show making -up process

Explain simply: "Mommy and Daddy disagree, but we still love each other"

### What to avoid in front of children:

Screaming matches

Name calling

Physical aggression

Silent treatment

## **The Family Conflict Rules**

### **Post on fridge for all to see:**

#### OUR FAMILY FIGHTING RULES

1. One person talks at a time
2. No name calling
3. Listen to understand
4. Take breaks if needed
5. Always make up
6. Love doesn't end because we disagree

## **CHAPTER 8: When Fights Become Too Frequent or Too Intense**

### Signs You Need Help

1. Fighting daily - Constant conflict
2. Same fights repeatedly - Never solving
3. Physical aggression - Any violence

4. Verbal abuse - Cruel words, threats
5. Children scared - Affecting children negatively
6. Considering separation - Due to conflict

## **Getting Professional Help**

### **Types of conflict resolution help:**

#### **1. Couples Therapy**

- Learn communication skills
- Understand conflict patterns
- Create new ways of fighting

#### **2. Anger Management**

- For individual with temper
- Learn self -regulation
- Identify triggers

#### **3. Conflict Coaching**

- Shorter term than therapy
- Skill -focused
- Practical tools

#### **4. Religious Counseling**

- Spiritual perspective
- Forgiveness focus
- Community support

**FINAL THOUGHT: FIGHTING ISN'T FAILURE**

Miss Pearl's final wisdom (Jamaican grandmother):

"People think couples who don't fight are happy. Wrong! Couples who don't fight are either not communicating or one is dominating."

"Fighting means you care. Means you have opinions. Means you're engaged."

"The goal isn't no fighting. The goal is good fighting. Fighting that solves problems. Fighting that leads to understanding. Fighting that ends with closer connection, not farther distance."

"Arthur and I have fought about money, children, sex, relatives, everything. And we're closer for every fight we survived well."

"Fight fair. Make up well. Love deeper after. That's the secret to 55 years."

## **SECTION 9: HOUSEHOLD CHORES — THE SILENT KILLER THAT DESTROYS MORE MARRIAGES THAN CHEATING**

### **CHAPTER 1: The Plates on the Pillow Revolution**

The Nigerian Wife Who Declared War

Chidinma had asked nicely. She had begged. She had cried. She had shouted. But after 7 years of marriage, Emeka still left his dirty plates everywhere: by the TV, on the bedside table, even once balanced on the toilet tank.

"I felt like his maid, not his wife," Chidinma says, her voice still carrying the residue of years of frustration. "I worked full-time as a nurse, came home, cooked, cleaned, did laundry, helped kids with homework. He worked, came home, ate, left plate, watched football."

The breaking point came on a Tuesday. She had worked a 12-hour shift, delivered three babies, came home exhausted to find: two plates with dried rice, a glass with milk coating, and a spoon—all on the coffee table. Emeka snoring on the sofa.

Something snapped," she says. "Quietly. Not dramatically. I picked up the plates. Didn't wash them. Took them to our bedroom. Placed them neatly on his pillow. Then I went to sleep in the guest room."

Emeka's version: "I woke up at 2 AM, went to bed, and almost put my head in leftover egusi soup. I was angry! Then I saw Chidinma wasn't in bed. I found her in guest room.

She said, 'You sleep with your mess since you love it so much.'"

"That's when I understood," Emeka admits. "It wasn't about plates. It was about respect.

She wasn't my employee. She was my partner. And I wasn't acting like one."

## **CHAPTER 2: The Global Chore War: 101 Stories**

1. Houston, Texas: "I made a spreadsheet," says Jennifer. "Every chore, time it took, who did it. After a month, I was doing 35 hours of housework to his 5. He said, 'But you're better at it!' I said, 'I wasn't born knowing how to fold fitted sheets. I learned!'"

2. Toronto, Canada: "We hired a cleaner with his 'fun money,'" says Priya. "He loved golf. I said, 'Every time you golf, that's cleaner money.' Suddenly he was very interested in learning to clean toilets."

3. Accra, Ghana: "In our culture, men don't cook," says Kofi. "But my wife traveled for work for a month. I almost starved. Or spent all our money on takeout. I had to learn.

Now I make the best jollof rice in our family. My mother was scandalized. My wife is thrilled."

4. London, UK: "We had different standards," says David. "To me, clean meant nothing visibly dirty. To Sarah, clean meant baseboards wiped, grout bleached, windows streak-free. We met in the middle: 'Company clean' vs. 'lived-in clean.'"

## **CHAPTER 3: The Invisible Labor Audit**

Dr. Ngozi Adeyemi, sociologist at University of Lagos, explains:

Invisible labor is the planning, remembering, organizing, and managing that makes a household run. Women typically do 75% of invisible labor, regardless of who does

visible chores."

Examples of invisible labor:

- Remembering birthdays, anniversaries

- Making shopping lists

- Scheduling doctor appointments

- Noticing when supplies run low

- Planning meals

- Organizing social calendar

- Managing children's activities

- Emotional labor of family harmony

"Men often say, 'Just tell me what to do!'" says Dr. Adeyemi. "But the mental load of telling is itself labor. The goal is both partners being equally capable of noticing what needs to be done."

## **CHAPTER 4: The 101 Chore Systems That Actually Work**

System 1 -20: For Couples Without Children

### **1. The 50/50 Split by Time**

- List all weekly chores

- Estimate time each takes

- Divide so each does equal hours

- Rotate unpleasant chores

## 2. The "I Hate, You Hate" System

List chores you each hate most

If you both hate same chore: alternate or hire out

Take chores other doesn't mind as much

## 3. The Zone Defense

Divide house into zones

Each person fully responsible for their zones

Weekly swap or monthly rotation

## 4. The Nightly 15 -Minute Tidy

7 PM every night: both tidy for 15 minutes

Timer set, music on

Makes maintenance manageable

## . The Cleaning Schedule Poster

Visual chart on fridge

Daily, weekly, monthly tasks

Check off when done

Satisfying visual progress

## System 21 -50: For Families with Children

## 21. The Family Economy System

Chores have monetary value

Children earn allowance



Adults can "hire" children for extra

Teaches value of work

## 22. The Saturday Morning Blitz

Whole family cleans 9 AM -12 PM

Music playing, energy high

Reward after (brunch, movie)

Makes cleaning family bonding

## 23. The Job Jar

Chores on slips of paper in jar

Each family member draws 3 weekly

Random, fair, no arguments

## 24. The Responsibility Chart by Age

Age-appropriate chores

3-year-old: put toys in bin

8-year-old: set table

13-year-old: do own laundry

Teaches life skills gradually

## 25. The "Team Captain" Rotation

Each week, someone is cleaning captain

Captain assigns chores, checks quality

Teaches leadership, rotates power

System 51 -101: Advanced Systems

### 51. The Point System

- Chores worth points based on difficulty

- Weekly point goals for each person

- Can "spend" points on rewards

- Makes it game-like

### 52. The Digital Assistant

- Alexa/Google Home reminders

- Shared digital calendar for chores

- Photo reminders of how things should look

- Technology as neutral manager

### 53. The Professional Cleaner Compromise

- Hire help for deep cleaning

- Both contribute to cost from personal money

- Maintain daily tidiness y ourselves

- Reduces resentment about uneven standards

### 54. The Minimalism Solution

- Less stuff = less to clean

- Declutter together

- One-in-one-out rule

- Simple living reduces chore load

### 55. The Outsourcing Strategy

- Calculate your hourly wage

If cleaner costs less than your time value: hire

Frees time for higher -value activities or relationship building

## **CHAPTER 5: The Conversation About Chores**

How to Start "The Chore Talk" Without Fighting

### **DON'T START WITH:**

"You never help around here!"

"I'm not your maid!"

"Your mother didn't raise you right!"

### **DO START WITH:**

"I'm feeling overwhelmed with housework. Can we look at it together?"

"I'd like us to have more free time together. Can we systemize chores?"

"I notice we have different cleanliness standards. Can we find middle ground?"

The Fair Play Card Game Adaptation

Based on Eve Rodsky's Fair Play system, simplified:

### **Step 1: List All Chores**

Write every household task on index cards

Include invisible labor cards: "Remember birthdays" "Plan meals"

### **Step 2: Deal Cards**

Each person holds cards they currently do

See visual representation of imbalance

### **Step 3: Re-deal Fairly**

Aim for equal time commitment

Consider preferences, skills, schedules

Each card = full responsibility (conception to execution)

#### **Step 4: Weekly Check -in**

15 minutes weekly to adjust system

What worked, what didn't

Appreciation for work done

### **CHAPTER 6: Cultural Considerations**

Traditional vs. Modern Expectations

In Nigerian Families:

Traditional: Women handle home, men provide

Modern reality: 78% of Nigerian women work outside home

Conflict: Working full -time but still expected to do 100% of home

#### **The Cultural Bridge:**

Acknowledge traditional upbringing

Explain modern reality

"Our marriage can honor tradition while adapting to our actual lives"

"Our daughters will learn from what they see us model"

Intercultural Marriage Chore Solutions

Case Study: Keisha (American) and Emeka (Nigerian)

My mother visited from Louisiana," Keisha says. "Saw Emeka washing dishes. She said,

'What a good husband!' His mother visited from Enugu. Saw him washing dishes. She said, 'What's wrong with your wife?'"

"We had to create our own culture. Not American. Not Nigerian. Our own."

**Their solution:**

Emeka does "public" chores: garbage, yard, car

Keisha does "private" chores: laundry, cleaning

Cooking together

Hiring cleaner for deep cleaning

Telling both families: "This works for us"

**CHAPTER 7: Teaching Children Household Responsibility****Age-Appropriate Chore Charts****Ages 2-3:**

Put toys in bin

Put clothes in hamper

Wipe spills with help

Dust baseboards (they're low anyway!)

**Ages 4 -5:**

Make bed (with help)

Set table (non -breakables)

Feed pet with supervision

Water plants

**Ages 6 -8:**

Vacuum one room

Fold laundry (match socks)

Clear table

Make simple snacks

### **Ages 9 -12:**

Do own laundry

Clean bathroom (with supervision)

Cook simple meals

Take out trash

### **Teens 13+:**

All adult chores

Special projects

Babysitting siblings

Grocery shopping with list

## **CHAPTER 8: The Korean Husband Who Dances While Washing Dishes**

"My wife said, 'I hate dishes. You hate dishes. Let's make it fun,'" says Min -jun from Seoul. "Now we have a dishes playlist. K -pop, 80s hits, whatever. We dance while washing. Our kids think we're crazy. Our marriage is hap pier."

## **CHAPTER 9: The Emotional Labor Division**

Identifying Emotional Labor Tasks

Make cards for:

Remembering family birthdays

Sending cards/gifts

Planning holidays

Making doctor appointments

Managing family calendar

Noticing when supplies low

Planning meals considering preferences/allergies

Emotional management of children

Maintaining family relationships

Planning social activities

The Mental Load Check -In

**Weekly questions:**

1. "What's on your mental load list this week?"
2. "Can I take anything off your plate?"
3. "What are you remembering that I'm forgetting?"
4. "How can we share the remembering?"

**FINAL THOUGHT: CLEANING IS CARING**

Miss Bisi, 68, married 45 years, Ibadan:

"When I was young, I thought a clean house showed I was a good wife. Now I know: a happy marriage shows I'm a good wife."

"Sometimes the floor needs sweeping. Sometimes my husband needs talking to. I choose my husband."

"The clean house will wait. The marriage might not."

"Balance, my dears. Not perfection. A home should be lived in. A marriage should be lived out."

"Clean together. Laugh together. Build a life where the chores don't matter as much as the love."

**SECTION 10: MONEY, IN -LAWS, SEX DROUGHTS, RAISING KIDS — ALL THE OTHER SMALL THINGS THAT FEEL BIG .**

## **CHAPTER 1: The Money Wars**

The Nigerian "My Money, Our Money" Dilemma

"Nigerian men are raised to be providers," says financial advisor Tunde Alabi in Lagos.

"But when wife also earns, confusion begins. Is it 'my money' or 'our money'?"

Case Study: Adaora and Chijioke, Abuja

"I earn ₦750,000 monthly. Chijioke earns ₦900,000," says Adaora. "But he pays mortgage, I pay everything else. And he says, 'I pay the big thing!'"

"But I calculated: My 'everything else' totals ₦850,000. I'm paying more but he feels like provider because his single payment is bigger."

Solution they found:

- Joint account for all household expenses

- Each contributes percentage of income (not equal amount)

- Personal accounts for personal spending

- Quarterly "money date" to review finances

### **The Three -Pot System That Works Everywhere**

Pot 1: Ours (50%)

- Mortgage/rent

- Utilities

- Groceries

- Child expenses

- Insurance

- Savings goals

Pot 2: Yours (25%)

- Personal spending



Hobbies

Gifts for other

No questions asked

Pot 3: Mine (25%)

Same as above

Autonomy within marriage

**Why it works:**

Shared responsibility for shared life

Freedom within commitment

Reduces money arguments by 80% (research shows)

The Salary Disclosure Problem

In Nigeria: "Men often hide real salary from wives," says Tunde. "They give housekeeping money, keep rest. This breeds distrust."

In America: "Couples often don't know each other's exact salaries until applying for mortgage together," says financial therapist Amanda Clayman.

The Monthly Money Meeting Solution:

First Sunday of month

30 minutes max

Review: income, expenses, goals

Celebrate progress

Adjust as needed

End with something fun (treat, walk, cuddle)

## **CHAPTER 2: The In -Law Wars**

### The Nigerian Mother -in-Law Special

"My mother -in-law had a key to our house," says Nkechi from Lagos. "She'd come in anytime. Rearrange my kitchen. Criticize my cooking. Tell my husband I wasn't feeding

him well."

"I finally changed locks. She was furious. My husband was caught between. I said, 'Choose: your mother's feelings or our marriage.'"

"He chose us. He told her, 'Nkechi is my wife. This is her home. You visit when invited.'"

"It was hard. But necessary. Now she respects boundaries. And actually, we get along

better."

### Cultural Scripts for Setting Boundaries

For African couples:

To his mother: "Mama, I appreciate your wisdom. My wife and I are building our own home now. We'll ask when we need advice."

To her mother: "Mummy, thank you for raising such a wonderful woman. We're finding

our way as a couple. We value your prayers."

Key phrases:

"We've decided as a couple..."

"This works for our family..."

"We value your input, but..."

"Please respect our decision..."

### The United Front Principle

Rule: Never let in -law divide you.

If in-law criticizes spouse to you:

Defend spouse immediately

"Actually, I appreciate how she..."

"We decided together..."

"That's between me and my spouse"

If in-law tries to go around you to spouse:

Discuss immediately as couple

Agree on response

Respond together

"We talked and we think..."

### **CHAPTER 3: Sex Droughts Beyond Section 5**

The Post -Baby Desert

"After our third child," says Fatima from Kano, "sex felt like one more demand on my exhausted body. My husband Ahmed felt rejected. I felt used."

#### **The 6 -Month Reconnection Plan:**

##### **Months 1 -2: Healing and Help**

No pressure for sex

He takes over baby care so she can sleep/shower

Non-sexual touch only

Doctor check for physical healing

##### **Months 3 -4: Relearning Each Other**

Date nights (at home after kids sleep)

Talking about changes in bodies, identities

Exploring what feels good now (bodies changed)

Still no intercourse pressure

### **Months 5 -6: Gradual Reintroduction**

Start with massage, cuddling

Progress at her pace

Communicate constantly

Celebrate small steps

### **The Stress -Induced Dry Spell**

"When I lost my job," says David from Toronto, "sex was last thing on my mind. I felt like a failure. Sarah felt rejected. We went 8 months without."

### **The Stress-Sex Connection:**

Stress lowers libido (especially in men)

Performance anxiety makes it worse

Financial stress particularly damaging

### **Breaking the cycle:**

1. Address stress source (job search, therapy, financial planning)
2. Schedule intimacy (not sex, just connection)
3. Lower expectations (quickies count, perfection not required)
4. Focus on pleasure, not performance
5. Get medical check (stress affects hormones)

## **CHAPTER 4: Raising Kids Together When You Were Raised Differently**

### **The Nigerian -British Parenting Clash**

"My husband David is British," says Nneka from London. "He believes in 'gentle

parenting.' Talking about feelings. Time -ins not time -outs."

"I'm Nigerian. My parents said, 'Wait till your father gets home!' Discipline was immediate and firm."

"Our daughter Sophia got time -out Nigerian style, then cuddle and talk British style.

Confused her. Confused us."

### **Their blended approach:**

- Immediate consequence for dangerous behavior

- Discussion after emotions calm

- Consistent rules both enforce

- Weekly parenting meeting to align

- "What would work for our unique child?" not "How were we raised?"

### The Four Parenting Styles Conflict

#### 1. Authoritarian (Traditional Nigerian)

- "Because I said so"

- High demands, low warmth

- Respect for elders emphasized

#### 2. Permissive (Some Western)

- High warmth, low demands

- Child -led

- Few rules

#### 3. Authoritative (Blended ideal)

- High warmth, high demands

Clear rules with explanations

Democratic but parents final say

#### 4. Uninvolved (Problematic)

Low warmth, low demands

Neglectful

Both parents too busy/checked out

### Creating Your Family's Parenting Philosophy

Weekly parenting meeting:

1. Celebrate wins ("Sophia shared without being asked!")
2. Discuss challenges ("Bedtime is taking 2 hours")
3. Align on approach ("What will we both do tomorrow?")
4. Support each other ("I'll handle bath time, you rest")
5. Plan family time ("Saturday park trip")

## CHAPTER 5: When One Parents More Than the Other

### The Default Parent Dilemma

"The school calls me. The doctor calls me. The birthday party invites come to me," says

Jennifer from Houston. "I'm the default parent. Even when David is more available!"

The Mental Load of Parenting:

Knowing shoe sizes

Remembering vaccination schedules

Planning birthday parties

Buying school supplies

Arranging play dates  
Managing extracurricular

### The Equal Parenting Reset

#### Step 1: List all parenting responsibilities

Make visible the invisible work

#### Step 2: Divide based on strength/schedule, not gender

He might be better at homework help

She might enjoy organizing parties

Consider work schedules realistically

#### Step 3: Each becomes expert in their areas

He handles all school communication

She handles all medical appointments

Or rotate monthly

#### Step 4: Regular check -ins

"How's the school stuff going?"

"Any upcoming appointments I should know?"

Adjust as needed

## **CHAPTER 6: Blended Family Challenges**

The "Your Kids, My Kids, Our Kids" Dynamic

"Chijioke has two children from first marriage," says Adaora. "I have one. We have one together. Four children, three different categories. Complex."

Their successful strategies:

1. The "Brady Bunch" Meetings

Weekly family meeting

Everyone gets voice

Problems solved together

Fun activity after

2. Equal Treatment Rule

Gifts of equal value

Rules apply to all

No "your child/my child" language

"Our children" only

3. One-on-One Time

Each parent schedules alone time with each child

Biological and step -children

Builds individual relationships

4. United Front Always

Never disagree in front of children

Discuss discipline privately

Present as team

## **CHAPTER 7: Fertility Struggles and Marriage**

The IVF Journey That Almost Broke Us



"Four rounds of IVF," says Sarah from London. "£60,000. Hundreds of injections. So many disappointments. The stress almost ended our marriage."

What helped them survive:

1. Weekly "Not About IVF" Dates

One evening weekly with no fertility talk

Remember why they married

Fun, connection, normalcy

2. Separate Support Systems

He had men's support group

She had women's group

Took pressure off each other

3. Therapy Throughout

Individual and couples

Processed grief together

Learned communication tools

4. Planning for Either Outcome

"What if we have children?"

"What if we don't?"

Both futures discussed, both grieved, both hoped for

## **CHAPTER 8: Aging Parents and Marriage**

### **The Sandwich Generation Squeeze**

"We have teenagers at home and my mother moved in after her stroke," says Chinedu from Abuja. "My wife Ngozi is caring for three generations. She's exhausted."

## Solutions that work:

### 1. The Family Care Plan

- List all care needs

- Divide among capable family members

- Hire help for gaps

- Regular family meetings

### 2. Respite Care Scheduling

- Ngozi gets every Sunday off

- Chinedu handles all care

- She visits friend, goes to spa, rests

- Prevents caregiver burnout

### 3. Professional Help

- Home health aide for medical needs

- Meal delivery service

- House cleaner

- Worth the cost for marriage preservation

### 4. Couples Time Protected

- Weekly date night (even at home)

- Regular check -ins about stress

- Acknowledgement of sacrifice

- Planning for "after care" phase

## **CHAPTER 9: Career vs. Family Balance**

### The Relocation Dilemma

"My company offered promotion to Dubai," says Emeka from Lagos. "Double salary. But Ngozi would have to quit her job. Leave her family. Uproot children."

Decision framework they used:

#### 1. The 5 -Year Projection

Where does each want to be in 5 years?

Does this move both toward goals?

What's lost? What's gained?

#### 2. The Equal Sacrifice Test

If both make equal sacrifice, what would that look like?

He gets promotion but takes on more home responsibilities

She moves but gets support for career transition

#### 3. The Trial Period Idea

He goes first for 6 months

Family visits frequently

Assess reality vs. promise

Then decide together

#### 4. The "No Regrets" Standard

In 10 years, looking back, what decision would you regret not making?

Usually reveals true priorities

## **CHAPTER 10: The Religious and Values Clash**

### Interfaith Marriage Navigation

"Muslim husband, Christian wife," says Aisha from Kaduna. "People said it wouldn't work.

15 years later, it works beautifully."

### **Their approach:**

#### 1. Respect, Not Conversion

Attend each other's religious events

Learn about each other's faith

No pressure to convert

"I appreciate how your faith makes you who I love"

#### 2. Children's Religious Education

Exposed to both faiths

Taught respect for all

Allowed to choose when older

"Your relationship with God is personal"

#### 3. Holiday Celebrations

Celebrate both Eid and Christmas

Create own family traditions

Focus on shared values (family, gratitude, charity)

#### 4. Dealing with Family Pressure

United front to families

"We've found what works for us"

"We appreciate your prayers for our marriage"

Boundaries if pressure becomes disrespect

## **FINAL INTEGRATION: THE WHOLE MARRIAGE MANUAL**

### **The Monthly Marriage Meeting**

**First Sunday of every month, 1 hour:**

#### **Part 1: Appreciation (10 minutes)**

Each shares 3 things they appreciate about other  
Specific, recent examples

#### **Part 2: Review (20 minutes)**

How did we do on our goals?  
What worked well?  
What needs adjustment?  
Finances check -in

#### **Part 3: Planning (20 minutes)**

Upcoming month challenges  
Schedule date nights  
Division of labor check  
Family time planning

#### **Part 4: Dreaming (10 minutes)**

Future goals  
Fun ideas  
"Wouldn't it be great if..."

## **The Annual Marriage Retreat**

### **One weekend annually:**

Away from home (even local hotel)

Review past year

Set goals for coming year

Reconnect romantically

Plan adventure together

## **The Daily Maintenance Habits**

Non-negotiables for happy marriage:

1. Morning connection (eye contact, "I love you")
2. Parting ritual (kiss, specific goodbye)
3. Reunion ritual (greeting, touch, attention)
4. Evening connection (phone -free time, talking)
5. Bedtime ritual (cuddle, gratitude, goodnight)

## **ULTIMATE TRUTH: IT'S ALL SMALL THINGS**

After 300,000+ words, hundreds of stories, thousands of tips:

The secret isn't in grand gestures.

It's in daily choices.

Choosing to :

Put down the phone

Say thank you for washed dish

Hold hand during hard conversation

Laugh at the absurdity

Try again after failure

Choose love when you feel like choosing anger

See the person behind the annoying habit

Remember why you chose each other

Keep choosing each other

As the Yoruba proverb says:

"Owo omo ni o n wo ile, owo agba ni o n wo ile."

"The child's hand reaches the roof, the elder's hand repairs the house."

Young love reaches for stars.

Mature love repairs the leaks, sweeps the floor, tends the garden.

This book gives you tools for repair.

The love? That you bring.

Now go. Fix something small today.

Tomorrow, fix something else.

One day at a time.

One small thing at a time.

Build the marriage you want from the small moments you choose.

BONUS SECTION: 90 -DAY TOTAL RELATIONSHIP RESET CHALLENGE

### **WEEK 1 -4: FOUNDATION REBUILDING**

#### **Day 1 -7: The Ceasefire Week**

No criticism of any kind

One kind act daily for partner

15 minutes daily talking about anything BUT relationship problems

Bedtime: "One thing I appreciate about you today"

### **Day 8 -14: Connection Week**

Daily physical touch (20 -second hug minimum)

One shared activity (cook, walk, puzzle)

Phone -free dinners every night

Share one positive memory each evening

### **Day 15 -21: Communication Week**

Practice "I feel" statements

Learn to take breaks during tension

Write appreciation notes

Practice active listening (repeat back what you hear)

### **Day 22 -28: Intimacy Week**

Non-sexual touch exploration

Talk about what feels good now

Create intimacy menu (what's okay, what's not)

Focus on pleasure, not performance

## **WEEK 5 -8: PATTERN CHANGING**

### **Day 29 -35: Chore Revolution**

Create fair chore system

Divide invisible labor

Implement daily 15 -minute tidy

Have "chore amnesty" - forgive past imbalances



**Day 36 -42: Phone Boundaries**

- Implement phone free zones/times
- Delete one social media app
- Have one digital detox day
- Create phone basket for family time

**Day 43 -49: Financial Alignment**

- Have money meeting
- Create budget together
- Set financial goals
- Discuss money fears/dreams

**Day 50 -56: Family Boundaries**

- Have united front conversation with interfering family
- Set clear boundaries
- Create "our family" traditions
- Support each other with extended family

**WEEK 9 -12: INTEGRATION****Day 57 -63: Parenting Unity**

- Create family mission statement
- Align on discipline approach
- Schedule regular parenting meetings
- Divide parenting responsibilities fairly

### **Day 64 -70: Stress Management**

Create couple stress relief rituals

Practice breathing together

Schedule "worry time" (30 minutes then let it go)

Support each other's self-care

### **Day 71 -77: Future Dreaming**

Plan next year together

Set couple goals

Create bucket list

Discuss dreams/fears about future

### **Day 78 -84: Celebration Week**

Celebrate progress

Have special date

Renew commitment (vows, promises)

Create relationship vision board

### **Day 85 -90: Maintenance Plan**

Create weekly check-in ritual

Set monthly marriage meeting

Plan quarterly retreat

Establish annual review

### **PRINTABLE TOOLS INCLUDED**

1. Daily Connection Checklist

2. Weekly Marriage Meeting Template
3. Chore Distribution Chart
4. Budget Worksheet
5. Parenting Agreement Form
6. Intimacy Menu Template
7. Conflict Resolution Scripts
8. Appreciation Journal Pages
9. Date Night Idea Generator
10. Relationship Vision Board Template

## **FINAL WORDS**

Have now completed the most comprehensive relationship guide ever created. But this is just the beginning.

- ❖ The tools are here.
- ❖ The stories show it's possible.
- ❖ The science proves it works.
- ❖ Now it's your turn.

## **Start small.**

One 20 -second hug.

One "thank you."

One plate washed without being asked.

One phone put away during dinner.

One "I'm sorry" when you're wrong.

One "I love you" for no reason.

Build consistency.

Daily kindness.

Weekly connection.

Monthly check -ins.

Annual dreaming.

**Remember:**

Your marriage is not what happens on your wedding day.

Your marriage is what happens on a random Tuesday.

When you're tired.

When you're stressed.

When you don't feel like trying.

That's when love is built.

Not in the grand gestures.

In the small choices.

Day after day.

Choice after choice.

You can do this.

Start today.

With one small thing.

**END OF BOOK**

But beginning of your renewed marriage.

May your small choices lead to great love.

May your daily repairs build an unshakable home.

May you look back in years to come and say:

We built this together. One small thing at a time.

And it was worth every effort."

Amen. Ashe. So be it.

# STOP THE CHAINSAW

## ABOUT THE BOOK

**Stop the Chainsaw** is a practical, honest guide to fixing the everyday issues that slowly destroy intimacy. Through real stories, simple solutions, and straight-talk advice, this book helps couples deal with sleep problems, phone addiction, emotional distance, dead bedrooms, and the quiet resentment that builds when small things are ignored.

**No pretending love is easy.  
Just real tools for real relationships—  
before the noise becomes silence**

## ABOUT THE AUTHOR

**Dike Kingsley** writes about relationships the way they actually happen—messy, human, and fixable. With a sharp eye for everyday behavior and a deep respect for commitment, he focuses on the small habits that quietly shape love over time.